



CITY: Pg 3

Delhi to get ‘Super Medical Hub’;
CM announces AIIMS-like model



NATION: Pg 5

‘Political misdeed’: PM writes to
Birla on now-defeated resolution



FILM: Pg 12

‘Dreamed of starring
in Imtiaz Ali’s films’

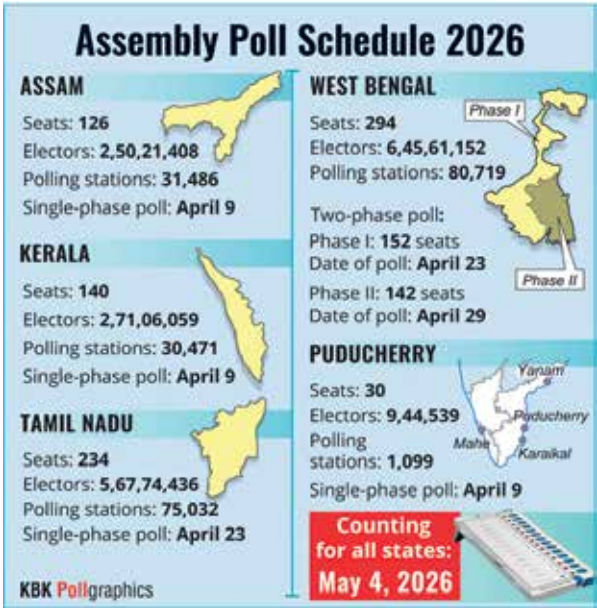
— GYANESH KUMAR DUCKS QUESTIONS ON OPPN MOVE TO REMOVE HIM AS CEC —
Five states, three dates: **Poll calendar out**

Assam, Kerala & Puducherry vote April 9; TN April 23; Bengal in 2 phases April 23 & 29

VINAY KUMAR

NEW DELHI: Assembly elections in Assam, Kerala and Puducherry will be held in a single phase on April 9. Tamil Nadu will go to the polls on April 23, while West Bengal will see a two-phase election on April 23 and 29, the Election Commission said while announcing the poll schedule on Sunday.

Results for all the states will be declared on May 4. The four crucial states and the Union Territory of Puducherry will, in all likelihood, see a high-voltage and politically charged electoral season that will be viewed as a test for the NDA, headed by the BJP and driven by the appeal of Prime Minister Narendra Modi as well as regional satraps. The NDA had posted impressive Assembly poll victories in



Bihar and Delhi. All eyes will be riveted

Kejriwal moves SC after CJ rejects plea to change judge

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Aam Aadmi Party convener Arvind Kejriwal and senior leader Manish Sisodia have approached the Supreme Court after the Chief Justice of Delhi High Court rejected their request to transfer CBI's plea against their discharge in the excise policy case from Justice Swarana Kanta

Sharma to another judge, the party said. According to sources privy to the development, the Chief Justice of the Delhi High Court, D K Upadhyaya, while declining the request by AAP leader and others discharged in the case, opined that Justice Sharma was hearing the CBI petition against the trial court's decision in

towards West Bengal which had voted in eight phases dur-

— **FOURTH INDIAN-FLAGGED VESSEL TO EXIT WAR ZONE UNHARMED** —
Through the smoke, Indian crude tanker sails

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: An Indian-flagged crude tanker sailed out safely from the UAE's Fujairah after loading oil, despite an attack on the oil terminal, as the government on Sunday said it is closely monitoring the situation in West Asia while ensuring stable fuel supplies and maritime safety.



A cargo ship is seen leaving the Dubai port, United Arab Emirates, Sunday

The vessel, Jag Laadki, carrying about 80,800 tonnes of Murban crude oil, departed

“LPG REFILL BOOKINGS HAVE DECLINED TO ABOUT 77L FROM 88.8L EARLIER, INDICATING SOME EASING OF PANIC BUYING”

Fujairah at 1030 hrs IST and is bound for India, with all crew members safe, the government

27, and the last on April 29. This time in West Bengal, polling will be held in 152 Assembly constituencies in the first phase and in 142 seats in the second phase.

It is learnt that leaders of several political parties, had expressed their views to the Election Commission officials this time that the polls should be held in two or three phases. A long drawn schedule not only hikes election expenses but also becomes tiresome for campaigners and public spirit about the democratic exercise. The BJP has made its presence felt in the political space in West Bengal and the party will make all out effort to shake the Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's citadel.

Apart from testing the tenacity of Brand Modi, the elections to Tamil Nadu, Bengal and



Continued on P4

Iran vows to hunt down Netanyahu

‘Child-killing criminal’



ASSOCIATED PRESS

TEHRAN/TEL AVIV: Iran on Sunday vowed to pursue and kill Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu as the escalating US-Israel war with Iran entered its third week, raising fears of a wider regional conflict and threatening oil supplies in the Gulf.

“IRGC vows to pursue and kill ‘child-killer’ Netanyahu if he is still alive,” Iran's IRNA news agency said in a post on X, referring to the country's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps. Rumours that the Israeli leader was dead circulated over the weekend, prompting

RISING TENSIONS

» The conflict continued to intensify across the region on Sunday, with Gulf Arab states reporting fresh missile and drone attacks

» Iran also threatened to widen its military campaign and called for the evacuation of three major ports in the United Arab Emirates

» Trump's call for countries to send warships to protect Hormuz brings no promises

Israeli strike kills 2 kids, pregnant mother

CAIRO: At least 12 Palestinians, including two boys, a pregnant woman and eight police officers, were killed Sunday by Israeli airstrikes in the war-torn Gaza Strip, hospital authorities said. A strike Sunday morning hit a house in the urban refugee camp of Nuseirat in central Gaza and killed four people, including a couple in their 30s and their 10-year son, according to the nearby Al-Aqsa Martyrs Hospital. The woman had been pregnant with twins, the hospital said.

The fourth fatality, a 15-year-old neighbour, was taken to the Awda hospital in Nuseirat.

See P10



KALINGA INSTITUTE OF SOCIAL SCIENCES (KISS)

Bhubaneswar, Odisha, India
A home for 80,000 Tribal children



KISS HUMANITARIAN AWARD 2025

16th March 2026

PAST RECIPIENTS

- Mr. Bill Gates**
Co-chair of the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation, and Co-Founder & former CEO of Microsoft (2023)
- Her Excellency Mama Rachel Ruto, EGH**
First Lady of the Republic of Kenya (2022)
- Mr. Ratan Naval Tata,**
Chairman Emeritus, Tata Sons (2021)
- Dr. Ary S Graça**
President-International Volleyball Federation (FIVB) (2020)
- Dr. Dansa KOUROUMA**
President, National Transition Council of Guinea, Guinea (2019)
- Professor Muhammad Yunus**
(Nobel Laureate)
Founder, Grameen Bank, Bangladesh (2018)
- His Holiness The 14th Dalai Lama**
Nobel Laureate, 2005 and Spiritual Leader (2017)
- Ms. Ashley Judd,**
Hollywood Actor, Activist & Global Goodwill Ambassador, UNFPA (2016)



Smt. Nita M. Ambani, Founder and Chairperson, Reliance Foundation receiving the prestigious KISS Humanitarian Award 2025

AWARDEES ARE FROM

5

Continents

13

Countries

2

Nobel Laureates
among the awardees

Chief Guest: Prof. Mohan Munasinghe, Nobel Laureate from Sri Lanka

- KISS Humanitarian Award
Founded by Dr. Achyuta Samanta, Founder, KIIT-KISS-KIMS
- Watch Live on Kalinga TV from 5.00 p.m. onwards

- His Excellency Dr Alejandro Toledo,**
Former President of Peru (2015)
- Ms. Anne F. Stenhammer**
Former Regional Programme Director, UN Women, South Asia Regional Office (2014)
- Madam Albina Du Boisrouvray**
Founder, Association François-Xavier Bagnoud (FXB International), Switzerland (2013)
- His Excellency Lyonchhen Jigmi Y. Thinley**
Hon'ble Prime Minister, The Royal Government of Bhutan (2012)
- Rt Hon. Lord Nicholas Addison Phillips**
President (Chief Justice) of the Supreme Court of the United Kingdom (2011)
- Rt. Hon. Sir Anerood Jugnauth**
Eminent Social Worker & His Excellency the President of Mauritius (2010)
- Dr. Ham Kee-Sun**
Eminent Educationist & Physician and Hon'ble President & Founder, Hanseo University, South Korea (2009)
- Ms. Edna Bomo Molewa**
Noted Social Worker & Hon'ble Cabinet Minister, Social Development, South Africa National Assembly, South Africa (2008)

The KISS Humanitarian Award is a prestigious annual international award conferred by the Kalinga Institute of Social Sciences (KISS) in Bhubaneswar, India, conceptualized and the brainchild of visionary humanitarian and educationist Prof. Achyuta Samanta, Founder of KIIT, KISS & KIMS. The award was initiated in 2008 to recognize and felicitate individuals for their exemplary and distinguished service to humanity across the globe.

PRAISES APNA GHAR ASHRAM'S SERVICE TO DESTITUTE

CM: Strict action against those spreading rumours about LPG

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Highlighting the role of social organisations in caring for society's most vulnerable, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday described Apna Ghar Ashram as a "living example of humanity and compassion" while announcing financial assistance for a paved road leading to the institution in Budhpur.

Addressing the 12th anniversary celebration and silver jubilee of Apna Ghar Ashram, the Chief Minister praised the organisation for its decades-long service to destitute, abandoned and ailing people, calling its work an inspiration for society.

Speaking at the event, Gupta said, "Apna Ghar Ashram is a living example of humanity and compassion. Institutions like this become a ray of hope for people who, for various reasons, find themselves separated from their families and society."

She noted that the organisation has spent the past 26 years providing shelter and care to those in need, ensuring essen-



Apna Ghar Ashram's work a beacon of compassion: CM MPOST

tial facilities such as medical care, food, clothing and proper attention so that residents can live with dignity. Highlighting the organisation's growth, the Chief Minister said Apna Ghar Ashram has now established a wide service network. "Over the years, the institution has expanded remarkably. Today it runs more than 70 centres across India, and its services are steadily expanding overseas as well," she said.

Gupta emphasised that social welfare cannot be car-

ried out by the government alone and requires collective participation. "Social service cannot be carried out by the government alone. It requires the combined efforts of both the government and society," she said. Assuring support to the organisation, the Chief Minister said the Delhi government would help resolve administrative issues related to the Ashram's development and operations, including arrangements for doctors and strengthening medical facilities.

No LPG shortage: Sirsa

NEW DELHI: Delhi Food Supplies Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa on Sunday said there is no shortage of LPG in the capital and warned of strict action against hoarding or panic-mongering.

He said the government is closely monitoring supplies, with around 70 joint teams comprising police, Weights and Measures, and Food and Supplies officials deployed to check stocks and prevent unfair practices.

Sirsa said global sup-

ply disruptions in the Gulf region had caused temporary tightness in markets, but the situation in Delhi remains under control.

He added that the sale of commercial LPG cylinders has begun as per directions from the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, with about 1,800 cylinders being supplied daily on a priority basis to essential sectors such as hospitals, schools, restaurants and dairies.

MPOST

ernments are closely monitoring the situation, and there is no reason for citizens to panic," she said.

Warning against misinformation and hoarding, the Chief Minister added, "If any individual or organisation is found involved in spreading such misinformation or wrongdoing, strict action will be taken."

North West Delhi MP Yogendra Chandolia, Narela MLA Raj Karan Khatri and senior BJP leader Shyam Jaju were also present at the event.

Fire in south Delhi market guts at least 50 shops: DFS

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A major fire broke out at Nature Bazaar in south Delhi's Andheria Mor area on Sunday morning, gutting around 50 shops and triggering a massive firefighting operation, an official of the Delhi Fire Services (DFS) said.

According to the DFS, a call regarding the blaze was received at 7.37 am, following which 10 fire tenders were rushed to the spot to control the flames. No injury to anyone was reported in the incident. The fire erupted at the Nature Bazaar market located near Andheria Mor in the Lado Sarai area, where several temporary and semi-permanent shops selling handicrafts and other items are set up, the DFS official said.



Thick plumes of smoke were seen billowing from the market complex as the fire rapidly spread through multiple shops in the crowded marketplace. Firefighters launched an extensive operation to contain the blaze and prevent it from spreading further.

Around 50 shops were gutted in the incident, causing heavy damage to goods and structures, the officer said.

Fire personnel completely doused the flames and carried out cooling operations in

the area. The cause of the fire is yet to be ascertained. Police officers also reached the spot to assist in crowd management and facilitate firefighting operations.

A PCR call was received at 7.33 am about a fire near Ambdekar Colony in Chhatarpur. On receiving the PCR call, maximum staff were immediately dispatched to the spot.

"On reaching the spot, it was found that the fire was raging at the Nature Bazaar, Delhi Haat, at Chhatarpur. No one was found trapped in the fire, however, the fire itself was found to be rapidly spreading. The fire was huge and five fire tenders were pressed into service initially. It took almost one-and-a-half hours to control the fire," a police officer said. The probable cause of the fire as per the night guards was a short circuit. No human casualties have been reported and only exhibition goods like

Civic body prepares comprehensive plan to clear legacy waste along railway tracks

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has launched a large-scale drive to remove accumulated waste along railway tracks across the Capital and has drawn up an action plan to ensure regular cleaning in the future.

According to officials, railway tracks stretching nearly 123 km across the National Capital Territory pass through several areas located close to slum clusters and JI colonies, leading to the dumping of large quantities of garbage over the years. Civic authorities estimate that nearly 15,000 metric tonnes of waste had accumulated along the railway



tracks across the city.

MCD officials said that around 5,000 metric tonnes of waste has already been cleared as part of the ongoing campaign.

Sanjeev Khirwar, Commissioner of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, said the civic body has prepared a compre-

“MCD has prepared a comprehensive strategy to address the issue of legacy waste along railway tracks while ensuring safety of sanitation workers

hensive strategy to address the issue of legacy waste along railway tracks while ensuring the safety of sanitation workers and smooth railway operations.

For the clean-up operation, the corporation has deployed about 145 vehicles, including trucks, auto-tippers, Hyvas and JCB machines, along with

nearly 800 sanitation workers across different zones of the city. Officials noted that waste removal work requires coordination with Indian Railways, as trains operate frequently on these routes and special operational blocks are required to carry out cleaning activities safely. The civic body has also proposed introducing a concessionaire-based system for zone-wise cleaning of railway tracks to ensure regular waste removal and prevent future accumulation.

In addition, MCD plans to conduct awareness campaigns with the help of councillors to discourage residents living near railway tracks from dumping waste in these areas.

Badarpur: 65-yr-old woman burnt to death

Police suspect accidental blaze while smoking in rooftop bathroom

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 65-year-old woman was charred to death after a fire broke out in the rooftop bathroom of a house in southeast Delhi's Badarpur area, with police suspecting that the blaze might have been triggered when she lit a matchstick to smoke a bidi, an officer said on Sunday.

The incident took place in the Molarband area on Saturday evening. Officials said a PCR call regarding a fire was received at the Badarpur police station. Soon after receiving the information, police rushed to the spot and found that a fire had broken out in the rooftop bathroom of the house.

KEY POINTS

- » Police found the woman's charred body inside. She was subsequently identified as Venu Singh (65)
- » The bathroom area contained wooden items and garbage that had also caught fire during the

incident: Police officer

» 'She had gone upstairs and the bathroom was filled with gas due to the leak. None of us knew about it because there was no smell. She probably lit a matchstick and that's how the fire started'. Daughter-in-law

Police found the woman's charred body inside. She was subsequently identified as Venu Singh (65). "The bathroom area contained wooden items and garbage that had also caught fire during the incident," the officer said.

According to a prelim-

inary inquiry, Singh used to smoke occasionally and would sometimes go to the secluded rooftop area to do so. Investigators suspect that the fire might have started accidentally while she was smoking in the enclosed space, leaving her trapped inside. Family mem-

bers, however, alleged that the blaze might have been caused due to a leakage from a piped gas connection installed in the house around two months ago.

"She had gone upstairs and the bathroom was filled with gas due to the leak. None of us knew about it because there was no smell. She probably lit a matchstick and that's how the fire started," the victim's daughter-in-law, Mamta Singh, said.

She said the victim sometimes smoked before having tea. Family members rushed to the rooftop after hearing shouts about the fire. Police said no foul play is suspected and the death appears accidental. The body has been kept at AIIMS for post-mortem.

Miranda House explores converting waste energy into electricity

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Researchers at Miranda House, a constituent college of University of Delhi, are working on innovative methods to generate electricity by converting everyday waste energy into usable power through environmentally friendly technologies.

The research initiative is being guided by the college principal Vijaylakshmi Nanda along with Monika Tomar, professor in the Department of Physics. The project

focuses on designing energy-harvesting devices using lead-free and eco-friendly materials to ensure that the process remains sustainable and safe for the environment.

As part of the study, researchers are developing thermoelectric and pyroelectric energy harvesters. These devices are capable of producing electricity from temperature differences or fluctuations in the surrounding environment. Scientists involved in the project say that even modest temperature variations can

Technology could prove useful in industrial settings, particularly around heavy machinery

generate measurable electrical output.

Such technology could prove useful in industrial settings, particularly around heavy machinery where heat variations are common. It may also have applications in loca-

tions that experience frequent temperature changes, allowing unused thermal energy to be converted into electricity.

Apart from temperature-based energy harvesting, the research also examines the possibility of capturing other forms of ambient energy, such as vibrations and movement in urban environments. If successfully developed, these technologies could help power small electronic devices and sensors while reducing reliance on conventional energy sources.

Alongside laboratory research, the college has already adopted renewable energy practices on campus. A 7 kWp grid-connected rooftop solar photovoltaic system installed at the institution supplies electricity to its waste management and recycling unit.

Officials say the initiative reflects the increasing role of academic institutions in advancing clean energy research while promoting sustainable practices within educational campuses.

Woman held for duping man of ₹20,000: Police

NEW DELHI: A 40-year-old woman was arrested for allegedly cheating a Delhi resident of Rs 20,000 on the pretext of arranging an easy loan through a social media platform, police said on Sunday.

The accused, Satvinder Kaur, a resident of Tilak Nagar in west Delhi, allegedly contacted the complainant with a fake loan offer and asked him to pay a pro-

cessing fee in advance. After negotiations, the victim transferred Rs 20,000, but she stopped responding and did not arrange the promised loan.

Police traced the money to Kaur's bank account and arrested her following technical investigation. The cheated amount and the mobile phone used in the fraud were recovered. Further investigation is underway. MPOST



HC asks Delhi Police to explain 'illegal' detention of activists

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Sunday asked the city police to file an affidavit explaining the circumstances and the authority of law under which it detained certain activists last week. The Delhi Police counsel said all detained persons have been released and the matter was "not so simple". The counsel also stated during the hearing that the FIR was confidential.

In a special Sunday hearing, a bench of Justices Navin Chawla and Ravinder Dubeja directed preservation of relevant CCTV footage showing how the police took them away.

The court, however, said it would consider the issue of preservation of CCTV footage of Special Cell office at a later stage and listed the matter for the next hearing on March 27.

It also listed for hearing on Monday a petition related to one of the detained activists, following his counsel's claim that he was yet to be released.

The police maintained that all persons have been released. "You will have to trace him," the bench said.

The Delhi High Court was informed that the missing activists allegedly detained by police had been released. The court directed the respondent to file an affidavit within a week explaining the circumstances and legal authority of the detention. Petitioners alleged activists were picked up illegally, not produced before a magistrate and subjected to abuse.

Music in the Park draws large crowds at Nehru Park: NDMC

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), in collaboration with SPIC MACAY and SRF Foundation, organised a classical music concert under its "Music in the Park" series at Nehru Park in Chanakyapuri in the evening. The open-air concert attracted a large audience of classical music enthusiasts from across the Delhi-NCR region.

The evening began with a Carnatic vocal recital by Sanjay Subrahmanyam, who was accompanied by violinist S. Varadarajan and mridangam artist Neyveli Venkatesh. The performance featured traditional Carnatic compositions and intricate improvisations, drawing appreciation from the audience.

The programme also featured a Hindustani violin recital by renowned violinist N. Rajam. She was accompanied by Ragini Shankar and tabla player Abhishek Mishra.



The recital showcased classical ragas and highlighted the expressive depth of the Hindustani violin tradition.

According to NDMC officials, thousands of people attended the event, including diplomats, government officials, corporate professionals, students and regular park visitors. The concert, set against the lush greenery of Nehru Park in the heart of the Capital, celebrated India's rich classical music heritage and created

an immersive cultural experience for listeners. The "Music in the Park" series will conclude on Sunday with performances by flautist Rakesh Chaurasia, accompanied by tabla player Ojas Adhiya, and Hindustani vocalist Ulhas Kashalkar, accompanied by Suresh Talwalkar and harmonium player Vinay Mishra.

NDMC says initiative promotes classical arts through live performances by leading and emerging artists.

MPOST

DEPLOY CRANES TO REMOVE OBSTRUCTING VEHICLES

Gurugram Traffic Police tow and fine 474 vehicles in wk-long drive

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

GURUGRAM: The Gurugram Traffic Police towed and challaned 474 vehicles during a week-long special enforcement drive against illegal parking across the city.

The campaign was conducted from March 8 to March 15 to ease traffic congestion and ensure smoother vehicular movement on busy roads and public spaces.

The drive was carried out under the direction of Police Commissioner Vikas Arora and the supervision of Deputy Commissioner of Police (Traffic) Rajesh Mohan.

Traffic police teams targeted vehicles illegally parked along roadsides, at major intersections, and in market areas and other public spaces that frequently witness heavy traffic.



According to officials, the vehicles were removed using cranes and challaned under provisions of the Motor Vehicles Act. Authorities noted that illegal parking remains one of the primary causes of traffic congestion in the city.

The enforcement operation was conducted with the assistance of cranes provided by the Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority

CLOSER LOOK

- » Officials said such drives are necessary to maintain road discipline, prevent traffic jams, particularly in busy commercial and residential areas where illegal parking is frequently reported
- » Alongside enforcement, police are also focusing on public awareness regarding the importance of following traffic rules

(GMDA), which were deployed at key traffic points to remove vehicles obstructing the free flow of traffic.

Officials said such drives are necessary to maintain road discipline and prevent traffic jams, particularly in busy commercial and residential areas where illegal parking is frequently reported.

Alongside enforcement, the traffic police are also

focusing on public awareness regarding the importance of following traffic rules.

Authorities urged citizens to park only in designated areas and avoid leaving vehicles in no-parking zones or along busy roadways.

Police said similar enforcement drives will continue in the future to ensure safer roads and smoother traffic movement across Gurugram.

MOVE FOLLOWS REVIEW OF RISING PATIENT LOAD

Delhi to get ‘Super Medical Hub’; CM announces AIIMS-like model

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push to modernise healthcare infrastructure in the capital, the Delhi government has unveiled plans to create a large integrated “Super Medical Hub” by merging three major government hospitals and strengthening specialised medical services across institutions. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced that Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital, Delhi State Cancer Institute and Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital will be integrated to form a unified autonomous institute on the lines of All India Institute of Medical Sciences.

The announcement was made after a high-level meeting chaired by the Chief Minister at the Delhi Secretariat to review the capital’s healthcare infrastructure and rising patient load. Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh and senior officials were also present during the discussions.



Explaining the rationale behind the move, the Chief Minister said strengthening healthcare requires a more scientific use of existing resources.

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TAKEAWAYS

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» “Strengthening healthcare requires the scientific and efficient use of available resources. Integrating them will allow better utilisation of doctors...”

more organised and advanced treatment,” she said.

The review highlighted a stark imbalance in hospital capacity and patient load. While Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital has a capacity of about 650 beds, only around 250 are currently operational, leaving nearly 400 beds unused. In contrast, GTB Hospital, originally designed for about 1,400 beds, is currently handling more than 1,500 patients.

Patient data further reflects

the growing pressure on major hospitals. GTB Hospital records over 14 lakh OPD visits annually and nearly 95,000 IPD admissions. Meanwhile, the Delhi State Cancer Institute treats about 1.27 lakh OPD patients each year, while Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital sees nearly 2.87 lakh OPD patients.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the integration will help distribute super-speciality services more efficiently. “Once

the institutions are integrated, super-speciality services will be distributed more systematically among hospitals, ensuring that patients receive the most appropriate specialist care,” she said. Under the proposed plan, Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital will strengthen departments such as cardiology, pulmonology, nephrology and gastroenterology, while the Delhi State Cancer Institute will emerge as the primary cancer treatment hub. GTB Hospital will continue to focus on major departments including orthopaedics, internal medicine, neurosurgery and ophthalmology.

The government has also announced plans to develop Institute of Human Behaviour and Allied Sciences on the lines of National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences as “NIMHANS-2,” further strengthening Delhi’s mental health and neuroscience ecosystem.

Verma reviews Rohtak Road drainage project

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major step to strengthen Delhi’s drainage infrastructure ahead of the monsoon, Delhi Cabinet Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma on Sunday inspected the ongoing storm water drain improvement project along Rohtak Road (NH-10) and reviewed flood control works aimed at tackling chronic waterlogging in several parts of West Delhi.

During the inspection, the minister reviewed the progress of the Public Works Department (PWD) project and said the work is nearing completion. Once finished, the upgraded drainage system is expected to provide significant relief to residents who have faced severe water accumulation during heavy rainfall for years.

The project involves the construction and improvement of a large storm water drainage network along the busy Rohtak Road corridor to ensure efficient flow of rainwater and prevent flooding on one of West Delhi’s key arterial routes. The drainage system is being developed from the Kirari Suleman



“An Irrigation and Flood Control proj worth Rs 23.51 cr has also been completed to divert water from the Kirari Suleman Drain”

Drain near Nangloi Metro Station to the Hiran Kudra Drain, covering stretches between Metro Pillar No. 428 and 626, and from Tikri Border to the Hiran Kudra Drain on both sides of the road.

The project, estimated to cost around Rs.113.98 crore, includes RCC drains with widths ranging between 1.2 metres and 2.25 metres, designed to handle heavy storm water flow during peak

monsoon conditions. Officials informed the minister that nearly 16,000 metres of the drain has already been completed, while about 2,200 metres of work remains.

Speaking during the inspection, Verma said the project aims to address a long-standing civic problem in the region. “For many years, people living in areas such as Mundka, Rajdhani Park and nearby localities have faced severe inconvenience during the monsoon season due to water accumulation. This project has been designed specifically to address that problem in a systematic and permanent manner,” he said.

Alongside this, an Irrigation and Flood Control project worth Rs.23.51 crore has also been completed to divert water from the Kirari Suleman Drain into the Supplementary Drain, improving drainage capacity in the area.

Verma said strengthening drainage infrastructure remains a priority. “Our goal is not just temporary relief but permanent infrastructure that works effectively year after year,” he added.

Tributes pour in for former CM Sahib Singh Verma on 83rd birth anniversary

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Hundreds of people from villages and neighbourhoods across Delhi gathered at Swabhiman Sthal in Ghevra Mor on Sunday to pay tributes to former Delhi Chief Minister Sahib Singh Verma on his 83rd birth anniversary, remembering his legacy and close connect with the common people.

Residents, supporters, social workers and community representatives attended a prayer meeting and havan organised at the memorial site. The gathering reflected the enduring respect many still hold for the late leader, who was known for his simple lifestyle and dedication to public service, particularly for Delhi’s rural areas.

Delhi Cabinet Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, along with family members, participated in the havan and offered floral tributes to a portrait of his father. Several people present at the venue also paid their respects and shared memories of the former chief minister.



Speaking to reporters, Parvesh Sahib Singh said the large turnout showed the deep bond Sahib Singh Verma had built with people across the capital. “Sahib Singh Verma ji always believed that politics is meaningful only when it improves the lives of ordinary citizens. Even today, people from villages and different parts of Delhi gather here to remember him. That connection with the people was his greatest strength,” he said.

Recalling his father’s tenure as chief minister, the minister said he had initiated several development works aimed at improving the lives of residents in villages, rural belts and unauthorised colonies. “When he was the Chief Minister, he started many initiatives for Delhi’s development and had several dreams for the future of the city. Unfortunately, after our government went out of power, many of those works could not continue,” he said.

Parvesh Sahib Singh added that the present government is committed to fulfilling those aspirations. “In the coming time, a comprehensive master plan will be implemented for the development of Delhi’s rural areas and unauthorised colonies,” he said.

He also said a Sports University is planned to be developed in Ghevra to nurture sporting talent and create opportunities for youth in the region.

The ceremony concluded with participants reaffirming their commitment to uphold Sahib Singh Verma’s values of simplicity, honesty and dedication to public service.

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Delhi Metro ridership rises to 235.8 crore in 2025, network remains largest in India

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Metro continues to strengthen its position as the country’s largest operational metro network, recording a significant rise in passenger traffic and reaffirming its role as the backbone of India’s urban mass transit system.

According to the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), the metro network handled 235.8 crore passenger journeys in 2025, marking a steady increase from 223.5 crore journeys recorded in 2024. The surge reflects the growing reliance of commuters on the system for daily travel across the national capital and neighbouring NCR cities.

The expansion of the network received a further boost with the inauguration of two new sections on the Pink Line and Magenta Line earlier this



month. With the addition of these stretches, Delhi Metro continues to remain the largest metro rail system in India and a key contributor to the country’s rapidly expanding urban rail network.

Highlighting the significance of the network, DMRC stated that “Delhi Metro continues to maintain its position as India’s largest operational Metro rail network, playing a pivotal role in the country’s rapidly expanding urban rail

“Delhi Metro runs 343 trains comprising 2,368 coaches and operates around 4,508 trips daily, covering more than 1.4L train kilometres every day”

ecosystem.” India currently has more than 1,143 km of operational metro lines across 26 cities, making it the third-largest metro network in the world. Of this, the Delhi-NCR network alone accounts for about 416 km with 303 stations, including the Noida-Greater Noida Metro and Rapid Metro Gurugram.

The Delhi Metro runs 343 trains comprising 2,368 coaches and operates around

4,508 trips daily, covering more than 1.4 lakh train kilometres every day.

It also maintains an exceptional punctuality level of around 99.9 per cent, making it one of the most reliable metro systems globally.

Passenger numbers have been steadily rising after the pandemic years. The highest ridership in 2024 was recorded on November 18, when 78.67 lakh passengers travelled in a single day. The record was later surpassed on August 8, 2025, when 81.87 lakh passenger journeys were recorded.

DMRC said the Delhi Metro has become the lifeline of urban mobility in Delhi-NCR, reducing travel time, easing congestion and promoting sustainable transport. Expansion under Phase IV is underway, with 52 new trains being procured, including 18 already delivered.

Interstate drug supply network busted: Police

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have busted an interstate network involved in the illegal supply of psychotropic medicines and arrested four people, officials said on Sunday.

The accused — Salman Khan from Patiala, Vipin Kumar Pal from Delhi, and Abdul Rehman and Ravi Garg from Uttar Pradesh — were allegedly involved in supplying banned drugs. Police seized 59,925 Alprazolam tablets and later recovered 2,000 Buprenorphine injections. Further investigation is underway, officials said. **MP05T**

MCD seals complex in W Delhi over ₹22 lakh property tax dues

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) sealed a four-storey commercial complex in West Delhi for non-payment of property tax dues as part of its ongoing drive against defaulters.

According to officials, the property located on the Najafgarh-Nangloi Main Road in Babrola was sealed after the owner failed to clear outstanding tax liabilities accumulated over several years. The civic body said the action was taken following repeated notices issued to the property owner

to settle the dues.

Ranjan Kumar, Joint Assessor and Collector of the West Zone, said the complex had pending property tax dues of approximately ₹22 lakh. Despite several reminders and official notices, the owner did not clear the outstanding amount, prompting the civic body to take enforcement action. Officials said the sealing operation forms part of the corporation’s intensified campaign to recover unpaid property taxes from defaulters across different zones of the city. The civic body has been conducting inspections and initiating legal

action against properties that have failed to comply with tax payment requirements.

The MCD stated that strict measures, including sealing and other enforcement actions, will continue to be taken against property owners who ignore repeated notices and fail to pay their dues.

The corporation has urged property owners and taxpayers to pay their property taxes on time to avoid penalties and legal action. Officials said timely payment of property tax is essential for maintaining civic services and infrastructure across the Capital.

More than 500 join animal rights march in west Delhi

NEW DELHI: Over 500 people participated in a march in west Delhi on Sunday evening, demanding stronger legal protections for animals and structural reforms to curb exploitation.

The ‘Animal Rights March Delhi 2026’ was organised by Delhi Vegans for Animal Liberation in collaboration with YV Care, One Just World, Vegan India Movement and World Vegan Vision, a release said.

According to the release, the march began near Pacific Mall and moved through nearby areas. Organisers said the demonstration sought

stricter enforcement of the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act and broader policy reforms to reduce cruelty.

Participants, including students, activists and professionals, carried banners and placards highlighting issues in industries such as dairy production, slaughterhouses, laboratory testing and entertainment, it stated.

Speakers at the gathering urged authorities to adopt policy measures to gradually reduce dependence on industries involving animal exploitation. They called for the promotion of plant-based

food systems and cruelty-free research methods, it said.

Addressing the crowd, activist Sai Vignesh said society must re-evaluate practices that normalise animal cruelty. Another speaker, Bhumika, said compassion should remain consistent across all forms of exploitation.

Co-organiser Manjira Banerjee said the initiative aimed to encourage public discussion around animal rights and policy reforms.

Another organiser, Indraneel Das, described the turnout as an effort by citizens to raise their voices for animals. **MP05T**

Man nabbed for manufacturing counterfeit auto parts in W Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Police have arrested a 33-year-old man for allegedly manufacturing and storing counterfeit automobile parts and packaging materials at a godown in west Delhi, an officer said on Sunday.

The accused, identified as Manas Hurria, a resident of Punjabi Bagh, was arrested following a raid conducted at a godown in Madipur village.

According to the police, a Crime Branch team, accompanied by an authorised representative of a private company, conducted the raid on Saturday. During the raid, Hurria was found at the godown and identified himself as the owner.

Police said the accused failed to produce any valid documents or authorisation regarding the manufacturing or dealership of the auto parts. A search of the premises led to the recovery of a large quantity of counterfeit materials bearing the label of a genuine brand.

The seized items included hundreds of counterfeit stickers, printed packing packets, engine oil filter packaging, brake shoe sets and various cables, including clutch, speed, and brake cables. Hundreds of air filters were also seized during the raid.

“We have also recovered 320 litres of engine oil packed in plastic containers inside cartons printed with the brand name,” the officer said.

Police also seized a barcode printer allegedly used to print labels for the counterfeit goods. All recovered items were confiscated and the accused arrested. An investigation is underway to trace the supply chain and distribution network.

Micro loan ceremony held as Speaker inaugurates Madan Das Devi Bhavan

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Emphasising the need to protect small vendors and women entrepreneurs from exploitative lending, Delhi Legislative Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta on Sunday inaugurated Madan Das Devi Bhavan and attended the 159th Micro Loan Distribution Ceremony organised by the community initiative Chaupal in the capital.

The event was held at Upasana Kunj in Rajpura Guramdi, where micro loans were distributed to beneficiaries as part of Chaupal’s efforts to promote financial inclusion and support small-scale livelihoods.

Addressing the gathering, Gupta highlighted the social impact of the initiative and praised the organisation’s efforts in empowering economically weaker sections. “Chaupal has come forward with a larger social purpose to empower women, strengthen



families and ensure that children receive education, households rise above poverty and people are able to live their lives with dignity,” he said.

The Speaker recalled witnessing the organisation’s growth from its early days and acknowledged the contributions of those who helped shape the initiative.

He said the sustained efforts of volunteers and supporters had transformed Chaupal into a meaningful grassroots movement focused on com-

munity service and social empowerment.

Drawing attention to the challenges faced by women working in weekly markets and small street-based businesses, Gupta said many of them remain outside the formal banking system and are often forced to rely on informal lenders charging high interest rates.

“Small vendors and women in weekly markets must be protected from exploitative lending,” he said, stressing the need for accessible and fair financial support.

He added that such financial assistance goes beyond economic aid and plays a crucial role in improving the lives of families. “For women running small livelihoods in our markets, access to fair credit is not merely financial support, it is a path to dignity, education for their children, and freedom from exploitative lending,” Gupta said.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Hundreds of residents, including youth, children and women, enthusiastically participated in the ‘Sundays on Cycles’ fitness event organised at Connaught Place on Sunday under the Fit India Movement, spreading awareness about healthy living and environmental protection.

Delhi’s Education and Sports Minister Ashish Sood, who attended the event as the chief guest, joined cyclists at the Block E of Connaught Place and encouraged citizens to adopt cycling as part of their daily routine.

The programme was organised with the support of the Sports Authority of India, Raaghiri Foundation and the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C). The initiative aims to promote regular physical activity and encourage



people to use cycling as a simple and effective way to stay fit.

Addressing participants, Sood said the initiative could become a mass movement promoting both fitness and environmental awareness. “Sundays on Cycles has the potential to become a major people’s movement that will not only inspire citizens to stay fit but also contribute to making the city environmentally healthy,” he said.

The minister noted that the cycling campaign has already

seen widespread participation across the country. “The ‘Sundays on Cycles’ campaign has so far been organised at more than 2.5 lakh locations across the country, with around 2.7 million cyclists actively participating,” he said.

Sood said the initiative originated from the Fit India Cycling Drive, launched in Delhi on December 17, 2024, by Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, and has since grown into a nationwide

movement with weekly cycling events held across cities.

Referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s message on fitness, he said, “In light of the Prime Minister’s call to combat obesity, it is essential that balanced physical activity becomes an integral part of our daily fitness routine.”

The minister added that the initiative is not limited to personal health but also carries an environmental message. “Promoting the culture of cycling will not only improve personal health but will also contribute significantly to environmental protection,” he said, noting that replacing petrol-driven vehicles with bicycles could help reduce pollution.

Sood also said the government is exploring the development of cycling-friendly lanes and infrastructure to enable citizens to use bicycles safely and conveniently.

— ANOTHER ACTIVE WESTERN DISTURBANCE LIKELY TO AFFECT FROM MARCH 19 —

Light rain, thunderstorms: Parts of north India get relief from recent heat

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI/LUCKNOW: Parts of northern India, especially the plain regions, received light rain accompanied by thunder in the past 24 hours, bringing relief from the recent heat.

Many areas of the national capital witnessed drizzle in the morning, with the India Meteorological Department stating that 8 mm of rainfall was recorded till 8.30 am.

“Due to a western disturbance approaching the western Himalayas, cyclonic activity has developed over central Pakistan adjoining Punjab and Haryana. As a result, parts of Delhi witnessed rainfall,” Mahesh Palawat, vice president of meteorology and climate change at Skymet Weather, said.

Palawat said the rain is expected the next day as well, and it is season’s first pre-monsoon rain, which has arrived



People walk with umbrellas during rainfall at the Ridge, in Shimla, on Sunday

PTI

Highlights

- » Uttar Pradesh, too, experienced light rain and witnessed a drop in temperatures in several parts of the state
- » Rajasthan too experienced a brief spell of light showers on Sunday

about 10 days earlier than usual.

Uttar Pradesh, too, experienced light rain and witnessed a drop in temperatures in several parts of the state.

According to the Meteorological Centre in Lucknow, the weather system triggered by western disturbances is expected to remain active till March 16, after which conditions are likely to turn dry on March 17 and 18, leading to a slight rise in temperatures.

However, another active western disturbance is likely to affect the region from March 19, bringing a fresh spell of rainfall starting from western Uttar Pradesh and spreading to several parts of the state till March 21, which may again bring temperatures close to normal levels.

The IMD has also warned of thunderstorms accompanied by lightning and gusty winds with speeds of 40-50 kmph

across the state, while isolated places in eastern Uttar Pradesh may experience hailstorms.

Rajasthan too experienced a brief spell of light showers on Sunday, with the local weather office saying weather conditions across the state are expected to remain largely dry on March 16 and 17.

However, a fresh and strong western disturbance is likely to become active over the region between March 18 and 21,

bringing the possibility of thunderstorms, gusty winds with speeds of 40-50 kmph and rainfall at isolated places.

The impact of the western disturbance is expected to be the highest on March 19 and 20, when parts of the Jodhpur, Bikaner, Ajmer, Jaipur and Bharatpur divisions may experience thunderstorms, strong winds and rain at some places, the weather department said.

Meanwhile, a few areas in the higher reaches of Kashmir, including the Gulmarg tourist resort, received fresh snowfall, while the plains were lashed by rains on Sunday, officials said.

The upper reaches of Gulmarg, including Apharwat and Kongdoori bowls, received snowfall, which continued till the last reports came in. Pir Ki Gali, along the Mughal Road in Shopian district of south Kashmir, and Sonamarg Zojilla axis also received fresh snowfall.

Man arrested over recruiting Indians for cyber fraud rackets

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested a man from Kanpur on suspicion of recruiting Indian nationals for organised cyber fraud rings operating scam dens in Cambodia, the officials informed on Sunday.

The accused, Krishna Kumar Lakhwani, was reportedly a part of a criminal network that promised Indians lucrative jobs overseas, such as data entry or customer support jobs, only to transport them to overseas fraud dens, where they were coerced into participating in cyber fraud.

The overseas fraud rings reportedly conduct large-scale online fraud operations from these compounds, operating outside the jurisdiction of law enforcement agencies.

The individuals who are transported to these locations reportedly face intimidation, detention, and coercion into participating in fraud opera-

tions such as digital arrest fraud or identity theft.

The accused reportedly collected between USD 300 and 400 from each candidate he recruited for these fraud operations.

He then transported them to Cambodia via routes that went through Delhi, a CBI official said.

The CBI reportedly apprehended Lakhwani based on actionable intelligence. The CBI intercepted the accused when he landed back in India. The CBI then took him to their office. The CBI reportedly searched his mobile phone with witnesses present.

The search reportedly yielded videos of him interviewing candidates for recruitment into these fraud operations.

Passport photos of several Indian nationals reportedly recruited by Lakhwani into these fraud operations were also reportedly recovered during the search.

AIIMS Rajkot intern doctor’s suicide: Five classmates held for harassment

OUR CORRESPONDENT

RAJKOT: A day after a 25-year-old intern doctor at the prestigious All India Institute of Medical Sciences in Gujarat’s Rajkot died by suicide leaving behind a note alleging assault by classmates, five persons were arrested, a police official said on Sunday.

The body of Ratankumar Meghwal, a native of Jaisalmer in Rajasthan, was found on a railway track between Ghaneshwar and Para Pipaliya near here at around 5:30am on Saturday.

Meghwal had been struck by a train, and his laptop, mobile phones, medical files and ID card were found near the tracks along with a 17-page note that accused his classmates of assaulting him, the official said.

— ENCROACHMENT ALONG GANGA —

Supreme Court directs Centre to submit comprehensive report

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has directed the Centre to submit a comprehensive report on illegal constructions along the banks and flood plains of Ganga river and inform about the steps taken to remove encroachments.

A bench comprising Justices JB Pardiwala and KV Viswanathan asked the Union government to place on record steps taken so far for implementation and execution of notification on rejuvenation, protection and management of Ganga.

“What are the impediments

or hurdles coming in the way of the Authority (National Mission for Clean Ganga Authority) in giving effect to the better and effective implementation of the notification, referred to above?”

“What steps the Authority intends to take to protect the river Ganga passing through all the States, referred to above, and ensure that the river plains and banks are free of all encroachments?” the bench said.

The top court issued notices to several Ganga basin states and said the issue required a broader examination beyond individual cases.

KARUR STAMPEDE

CBI grills TVK chief Vijay for more than 7 hours

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The CBI questioned actor and TVK chief Vijay for over seven hours at its headquarters here on Sunday over last year’s stampede during his rally in Tamil Nadu’s Karur that claimed 41 lives, officials said.

The actor left the agency headquarters after the questioning and related formalities got over around 6 pm, they said. This was the third session of questioning for Vijay. He has been examined twice in January.

Vijay was earlier summoned on March 9. However, he had requested that the date be deferred by 15 days, officials said.

The actor had also urged that the questioning be con-



TVK chief Vijay waves as he leaves the CBI headquarter, in New Delhi PTI

ducted in Chennai or any office in Tamil Nadu, citing political engagements prior to the upcoming Assembly elections, they said.

However, both requests

were declined by the agency, which summoned the actor to its headquarters here on Sunday.

The central probe agency has also asked the DMK MLA from Karur, Senthil Balaji, to appear before it for questioning on March 17, officials said.

The CBI took over the case from an SIT following a Supreme Court order and has been gathering evidence related to the September 27, 2025, stampede that claimed 41 lives and left more than 60 people injured during Vijay’s rally in Tamil Nadu’s Karur.

In October last year, the apex court asked the CBI director to appoint a senior officer to take over the investigation and also constituted a supervisory committee headed by for-

mer Supreme Court judge Ajay Rastogi to monitor the agency’s investigation.

A bench comprising Justices J K Maheshwari and N V Anjaria had said the stampede has left an imprint in the minds of citizens throughout the country. It has wide ramifications with respect to the lives of citizens, and enforcing the fundamental rights of the families who lost their kin is of utmost importance, the court had said.

“The faith and trust of the general public in the process of investigation must be restored in the criminal justice system, and one way to instil such trust is by ensuring that the investigation in the present case is completely impartial, independent and unbiased,” the bench had said.

From Page 1 Five states

Kerala will offer the BJP an opportunity to shed the tag of being a “North Indian party”. The BJP’s triumphs in the South have been limited to Karnataka. In Kerala, it will face a resurgent Congress-led UDF and the ruling LDF under Pinarayi Vijayan.

These elections will see the BJP trying to retain power in Assam, while it will be pitted against ruling parties in West Bengal, Kerala and Tamil Nadu. Puducherry is governed by NDA partner All India N R Congress.

A total of 17.4 crore voters are eligible to vote in the elections to five Assemblies with 824 constituencies, Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar said at a press conference here. The CEC was flanked by the two Election Commissioners -- Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi.

The model code of conduct has come into effect immediately with the announcement of the poll schedule. Tamil Nadu, West Bengal and Kerala are currently ruled by opposition DMK, Trinamool Congress and Left Front, respectively.

There are 234 Assembly seats in Tamil Nadu where DMK leader M K Stalin has been the chief minister since 2021. West Bengal has a total of 294 Assembly seats with TMC leader Mamata Banerjee in power since 2011.

Kerala has 140 seats and Left leader Pinarayi Vijayan has been the chief minister since 2016, leading the Left Democratic Front (LDF) government.

In Assam, there are 126 Assembly seats, and the BJP has been in power in the Northeastern state since 2016. Himanta Biswa Sarma has been the chief minister since 2021.

Puducherry Chief Minister N Rangasamy has been in power since 2021. The UT has a total of 30 seats where polling will take place.

CEC Kumar said the elec-

tions must be free of violence or inducement and warned that the EC will take strong action against any violation. He said presiding officers at all polling booths will upload voter turnout data every two hours and immediately after voting ends.

“The Election Commission will ensure greater transparency in the counting of votes and announcement of results. Election Commission has asked all enforcement agencies to ensure elections are impartial and violence-free,” he said.

The term of the Assembly will come to an end in West Bengal on May 7, in Tamil Nadu on May 10, in Assam on May 20, in Kerala on May 23, and in Puducherry on June 15.

There are 6.4 crore voters in West Bengal, 5.67 crore in Tamil Nadu, 2.7 crore in Kerala, 2.5 crore in Assam and 9.44 lakh in Puducherry.

There will be 2,18,807 polling stations in all four states and one UT -- of which 31,486 booths are in Assam, 30,471 in Kerala, 75,032 in Tamil Nadu, 80,719 in West Bengal and 1,099 in Puducherry.

Bypolls to five Assembly seats in Goa, Karnataka, Nagaland and Tripura will be held on April 9 and in another three constituencies of Gujarat and Maharashtra on April 23, CEC Kumar said.

Kumar said the counting of votes for bye-elections will be held on May 4 for all eight constituencies. The bypolls in all eight constituencies were necessitated due to death of sitting MLAs.

The eight constituencies are: Ponda in Goa, Bagalkot and Davnagere South in Karnataka, Koridang in Nagaland, Dharmanagar in Tripura, Umreth in Gujarat, and Rahuri and Baramati in Maharashtra.

Meanwhile, Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar ducked questions on the Opposition’s notice to move a motion in Parliament for his removal from the post.

At a press conference held to announce Assembly election schedules in four states and a Union Territory, Kumar did not answer questions on the Opposition notice.

Iran vows

his office to issue a statement calling the reports “fake.”

The conflict continued to intensify across the region on Sunday, with Gulf Arab states reporting fresh missile and drone attacks. Iran also threatened to widen its military campaign and called for the evacuation of three major ports in the United Arab Emirates, signalling the possibility of further escalation in the strategic Gulf region.

Iran launched several barrages of missiles toward Israel during the day, triggering air-raid sirens and forcing residents to rush to shelters. Multiple strikes hit central Israel, including areas around Tel Aviv. Israel’s national emergency service Magen David Adom released footage showing a large crater in a street and shrapnel damage to nearby apartment buildings.

Authorities said strikes in the Tel Aviv region caused damage at 23 sites and sparked a small fire. Israeli military officials said Iran has increasingly been using cluster munitions capable of scattering submunitions across multiple locations, making interception more difficult.

The war has already taken a heavy human toll across the region. According to the International Committee of the Red Cross, more than 1,300 people have been killed in Iran since the fighting began. Iran’s Health Ministry said the dead include 223 women and 202 children.

In Israel, Iranian missile strikes have killed at least 12 people and injured several others, including three people wounded in attacks on Sunday. At least 13 members of the United States Armed Forces have also died since the conflict began, six of them in a plane crash in Iraq last week.

The conflict has also severely affected Lebanon, where the Iran-backed militant group Hezbollah has been exchanging fire with Israel. Lebanon’s Health Ministry says at least 820 people have been killed and about 850,000 displaced since the clashes intensified.

In Beirut, displaced families were seen repairing rain-damaged tents while waiting for the violence to subside. Residents expressed uncertainty over when they might be able to return home as rescue crews continued clearing rubble from damaged neighbourhoods.

Meanwhile, US President Donald Trump’s appeal to China, France, Japan, South Korea, Britain and others to send warships to keep the Strait of Hormuz “open and safe” brought no commitments on Sunday as oil prices soar during the Iran war.

US Energy Secretary Chris Wright told NBC he has been “in dialogue” with some of the countries, and said he expected China “will be a constructive partner” in reopening the strait through which one-fifth of global oil exports normally pass.

Iran’s foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, told CBS that Tehran has been “approached by a number of countries” seeking safe passage for their vessels, “and this is up to our military to decide.” He said a group of vessels from “different countries” had been allowed to pass, without providing details.

Iran has said the strait is open to all except the United States and its allies.

“We don’t see any reason why we should talk with Americans” about finding a way to end the war, Araghchi added, noting that Israel and the US started the fighting with coordinated attacks on Feb 28 during indirect US-Iran talks. The talks focused on Iran’s nuclear programme, and Araghchi said Tehran had “no plan to recover” enriched uranium that is under rubble following US and Israeli attacks last year.

Indian crude

safely from Fujairah at 1030 hrs IST today (Sunday) carrying about 80,800 tonnes of Murruban crude oil and is bound for India,” the update said.

“The vessel and all Indian seafarers onboard are safe.”

On Saturday, two Indian-flag LPG carriers - Shivalik and Nanda Devi - carrying about

92,712 tonnes of LPG crossed the war-hit Strait of Hormuz.

Shivalik is due to reach Mundra port in Gujarat on March 16, and Nanda Devi would dock at Kandla port on March 17, according to the update. The two ships were among the 24 ships that were stranded on the west side of the strait since the war broke out in the region.

India imports about 88 per cent of its crude oil, 50 per cent of its natural gas and 60 per cent of its LPG needs. Before the US-Israel strikes on Iran on February 28 and Tehran’s retaliation, more than half of India’s crude imports, about 30 per cent of gas and 85-90 per cent of LPG imports came from West Asian countries, such as Saudi Arabia and the UAE.

The conflict has led to a blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, the main transit route for Gulf energy supplies. While India has partly offset crude supply disruptions by sourcing oil from countries, including Russia, gas supplies have been curtailed to industrial users and LPG availability to commercial establishments, such as hotels and restaurants, has been reduced.

Meanwhile, even as LPG woes of consumer continue to pose hardships to them in securing a refill, LPG refill bookings have declined to about 77 lakh from 88.8 lakh earlier, indicating some easing of panic buying. The government said there is no shortage of petrol, diesel or cooking gas, and supplies remain stable despite the West Asia conflict.

In a daily update on the impact of the West Asia situation, the government said the share of online LPG bookings has risen to about 87 per cent from 84 per cent, attributing the increase to a campaign by oil marketing companies promoting digital booking and discouraging people from queuing up at LPG dealerships for panic purchases.

All domestic “refineries are operating at high capacity and maintaining adequate crude oil inventories,” the update said.

“The country remains self-sufficient in the production of petrol and diesel, requiring no imports of the fuels to meet domestic

demand.”

Oil marketing companies have reported no dry-outs at fuel retail outlets or LPG distributorships, and petrol, diesel and LPG supplies are being maintained regularly.

The government said it continues to prioritise the interests of domestic consumers and ensure uninterrupted LPG supply, particularly for households and priority sectors such as hospitals and educational institutions.

Several States and UTs, including Bihar, Delhi, Haryana and Rajasthan, have issued orders for allocation of non-domestic LPG in line with government guidelines.

State governments are undertaking enforcement measures to prevent hoarding and black marketing of petrol, diesel and LPG.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Kejriwal

accordance with the roster and there was no reason to pass an order of transfer on the administrative side.

A call for recusal has to be taken by the judge concerned, the chief justice clarified.

The CBI’s petition is listed for hearing before Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma on Monday.

The Aam Aadmi Party said both Kejriwal and Sisodia have challenged the decision in the SC.

On March 11, Kejriwal, Sisodia, along with other accused in the excise policy case, made a representation to Chief Justice Upadhyaya to transfer CBI’s plea against their discharge from Justice Sharma to another “impartial” judge.

In the representation, Kejriwal claimed he has a “grave, bona fide, and reasonable apprehension” that the hearing in the matter would not be impartial and neutral.

On February 27, the trial court discharged Kejriwal, Sisodia and 21 others and pulled up the CBI, saying its case was wholly unable to survive judicial scrutiny and stood discredited in its entirety.

On March 9, Justice Sharma’s

bench stayed the trial court’s recommendation on the initiation of departmental action against the CBI’s investigating officer in the liquor policy case.

Issuing notice to all 23 accused on CBI’s plea against their discharge, Justice Sharma said certain observations and findings of the trial court at the stage of framing of charges prima facie appeared erroneous and needed consideration.

Kejriwal claimed in the representation that his apprehension was based on Justice Sharma’s past conduct and said that on the very first day of the CBI’s revision petition against his discharge, she proceeded to record a prima facie view that the trial court’s detailed order was “erroneous”, even without hearing the other side.

Justice Sharma, Kejriwal’s representation contended, did not disclose any “specific perversion” when she stayed the trial court’s directions against the CBI official.

The AAP leader also objected to Justice Sharma’s direction on deferring the trial proceedings in the connected ED case.

He submitted that Justice Sharma has decided multiple cases arising from the CBI FIR, including Kejriwal’s petition against his arrest and bail applications by AAP leaders Manish Sisodia and Sanjay Singh, as well as Telangana Jagruti president K Kavitha, and “not even once” given relief to any of the accused.

The representation added that Justice Sharma, while dealing with these earlier pleas, has already recorded “elaborate prima facie observations accepting the prosecution theory on critical questions”.

It informed the chief justice that three of the judgments have been set aside by the Supreme Court and one has been referred to a larger bench.

In the representation, Kejriwal said the case against him was politically motivated and his request to transfer the pending matter to another judge was “not directed at any personal predilection, but at the objective test of reasonable apprehension in the mind of a fair-minded and informed litigant seeking justice”.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

SLAMS OPPOSITION

‘Political misdeed’: PM writes to Birla on now-defeated resolution

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a sharp attack at the Congress, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said the resolution brought against Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla was driven by motives of self-interest and that certain individuals steeped in “dynastic mindset” want to confine democratic institutions within their own narrow spheres.

Prime Minister Modi made the remarks in a letter to Birla, days after the resolution moved by the Congress-led Opposition for the removal of the Lok Sabha speaker from office was defeated in the House.

Expressing gratitude for the letter, Birla said the Prime Minister has always held an unwavering faith in the rules, procedures, and traditions of India’s parliamentary democracy.

In his letter in Hindi, Modi said, “The no-confidence



Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla

motion brought against you in the Lok Sabha was defeated in the House. I also congratulate the members of the House for the decisive manner in which they rejected this political misdeed.”

“I listened attentively to the statement you delivered in the House following the defeat of

Highlights

- » Birla said the Prime Minister has always held an unwavering faith in the rules, procedures
- » The no-confidence motion brought against you in the Lok Sabha was defeated in the House, said PM

the no-confidence motion. The balance, patience, and clarity with which you referenced parliamentary history, the duties of the Speaker, and the supremacy of the rules were truly impressive. For this, I offer you my commendation,” he said.

“Your statement was not merely a response to that specific moment; rather, it served as a profound and measured exposition of Indian parliamentary traditions and democratic propriety,” the prime minister said.

The greatest strength of Indian democracy lies in its constitutional institutions, Modi said, adding Parliament stands as the supreme forum among these institutions.

Every voice raised in this House represents the hopes and aspirations of millions of citizens across the country, he said.

“In such a context, the responsibility of the Lok Sabha Speaker extends beyond merely conducting the proceedings; the Speaker also serves as the guardian of democratic traditions, parliamentary rules, and institutional dignity. The clarity with which you asserted in your statement that no one in this House stands above the rules” delivers a message that reaffirms the fundamental spirit of our democracy,” Modi said in his letter to Birla.

“Differences of opinion are inherent in a democracy. Indeed, it is the diversity of ideas that infuses democracy with vitality. However, it is equally true that there exists a distinct demarcation between disagreement and disrespect,” the prime minister said.

It is a matter of concern for all those who place their faith in democracy and its institutions that, at times, political disagreement appears to morph into a disregard for parliamentary decorum, Modi said.

Such moments, he said, serve as a true test for the individual occupying the Chair. The restraint, composure, and impartiality with which you navigated these circumstances are truly commendable, the prime minister said.

“Every citizen of this nation who cherishes democratic ideals sensed that the no-confidence motion brought against you was driven by motives of personal self-interest and arrogance,” Modi said, in a swipe at the Congress and the Opposition.

POLL SCHEDULE WITH SURPRISES

Condensed voting period, delayed counting in 5 state Assemblies

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The election schedule for five Assemblies announced on Sunday has thrown out quite a few surprises -- fewer phases, a condensed 20-day voting period, but longer gaps between the three polling days and a delayed counting.

The previous round of elections for these five Assemblies in 2021 had as many as eight voting days spread across almost a month, while votes were counted on the third day after the last polling date.

This time, votes would be counted on the fifth day after the last day of voting.

The gap is longer between the first two days of voting -- first on April 9 and the second on April 23 -- while the last polling day will be on April 29.

The last Assembly election, in Bihar in November 2025, also saw two polling days -- November 6 and 11 -- spread across five days, while votes were counted three days later, on November 14.

Some Opposition leaders

Closer Look

- » This time, votes would be counted on the fifth day after the last day of voting
- » Some Opposition leaders have alleged that the BJP wanted a delayed election

have alleged that the BJP wanted a delayed election in politically crucial West Bengal due to public anger over the LPG crisis, while others see it as the saffron party getting more time to campaign there.

The 2024 Lok Sabha elections had seven polling days spread across nearly 40 days, while counting had taken place on the third day after the last round of polling. Elections for four Assemblies also took place alongside the Lok Sabha polls, which required greater manpower and security arrangements.

The 2024 Lok Sabha election

was held in seven phases -- April 19, April 26, May 7, 13, 20, 25 and June 1. The counting of votes took place on June 4.

The last round of Assembly polls in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Assam and the Union Territory of Puducherry were held in nearly a month’s period, with West Bengal having eight phases -- March 27, April 1, 6, 10, 17, 22, 26 and 29.

Responding to a question on compressed phases this time, Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar told a press conference here on Sunday that there was a feeling to reduce phases and make things “comfortable”.

While Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Puducherry had single-phase polls in 2021, Assam had three phases on March 27, April 1 and April 6. The counting of votes then took place on May 2 after the last phase of voting on April 29 in West Bengal.

When contacted, EC officials gave no specific answer to the queries, but said phases have been compressed for the benefit of the voters.

KERALA ASSEMBLY POLLS

CPI(M) announces 81 candidates; CM Vijayan, 11 ministers in fray

OUR CORRESPONDENT

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and 11 of his cabinet colleagues were among the 81 candidates announced by the ruling CPI(M) on Sunday for the April 9 Assembly polls in the state.

The list was released by CPI(M) state secretary M V Govindan at a press conference here soon after the schedule of the election was declared by the Election Commission in New Delhi.

Of the 81 candidates announced, six are party-backed independents. The independent candidates for the five constituencies-Koduvalli, Kottakkal, Kon-

‘Vijayan is the only member of the CPI(M) Politburo contesting the polls’

dotty, Tirur and Palakkad-will be declared soon, he said.

As many as 56 sitting MLAs are in the fray, he said, adding that 11 ministers besides CM Vijayan, are figured in the candidates list.

Vijayan is the only member of the CPI(M) Politburo contesting the polls, Govindan said.

However, A N Shamseer, who is now serving as Assembly Speaker, and M M Mani, a party veteran from high range Idukki

district, failed to find a place on the list.

While Vijayan has been fielded in his sitting seat Dharmadam in Kannur district, senior leader K K Shailaja has been shifted to Peravoor from her current bastion-Mattannoor.

Apart from Vijayan, the ministers contesting the polls are O R Kulu (Mananthavady), P A Mohammed Riyas (Beyyapora), V Abdurahiman (Tanur), M B Rajesh (Thirithala), R Bindu (Irinjalakuda), P Rajeev (Kalamassery), V N Vasavan (Ettumanoor), Sajji Cherian (Chengannur), Veena George (Aranmula), K N Balagopal (Kottarakkara) and V Sivankutty (Nemom).

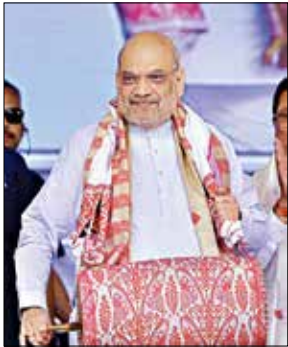
OUR CORRESPONDENT

GUWAHATI: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Sunday said he is confident that the BJP will return to power in Assam under the leadership of Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma with the “largest ever mandate”.

Addressing the youth convention of the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha (BJYM) here, Shah urged the people to give another mandate to the BJP and assured them that “every infiltrator will be sent out of India”.

His comment comes on a day when the Election Commission (EC) announced that the Assam Assembly elections would be held on April 9 and the counting on May 4.

“I am confident that the BJP will again form a government in Assam with the largest



Union minister Amit Shah during 'Yuva Shakti Samaroh' in Guwahati

ever mandate and power of the youths,” he said.

In the current 126-member Assembly, the ruling BJP’s strength is 64, while its allies AGP has nine MLAs, UPPL has seven, and the BPF has three members.

“The Congress gave shel-

ter to infiltrators, but the BJP government is determined to identify each one of them and drive them out of the country,” Shah said.

The EC conducted Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in some states, but the Congress protested against the exercise, he claimed.

“The Congress legalised, formalised and normalised infiltration, but the BJP will remove each illegal immigrant from the electoral rolls. Rahul Babu can rest assured that not only their (infiltrators’) names will be removed from the electoral rolls, but they will also be driven out,” Shah said.

He praised the chief minister for carrying out the eviction of infiltrators who had settled on land encroached by them. “Sarma has already

cleared 1.5 lakh bighas of land encroached by infiltrators, and the day will come soon when there will not be a single one left in the country,” he added.

During the Congress rule, Assam was “known for violence”, and several youths were killed, Shah claimed.

“The Congress did nothing for the youth, but its leaders were only concerned about the benefits of their families,” he added.

Shah alleged that the grand old party believes in “corruption, polarisation by promoting infiltrators and looking after the interests of their children”, and claimed that the BJP’s focus has been on “development, driving out infiltrators and ensuring that the interests of the children of poor people are taken care of”.

EC asks federal probe agencies, security forces to check black money, drugs

NEW DELHI: The Election Commission (EC) has directed central investigative and security agencies to mount a special vigil and take “proactive” measures to check the use of black money, drugs and other illegal inducements during the upcoming polls to five legislative Assemblies.

The poll body on Sunday announced the election schedule for four states of Assam, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal apart from the Union Territory of Puducherry during a press conference held here.

The EC, soon after the presser, issued separate communications to the Central Board of Direct Taxes (for the Income-Tax Department), Enforcement Directorate, Financial Intelligence Unit, Narcotics Control Bureau and the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence, among others.

It also sent letters to forces like the BSF, SSB and RPF asking them to step up their vigil and deploy special teams so that elections are held on a level-playing field, without the use of illegal cash and other inducements.

The Commission asked the CBDT to direct the I-T investigation wings in these poll-bound regions to deploy teams at airports, major railway stations, hotels, farm houses, Hawala agents and financial brokers to check for “unaccounted” cash.

It asked the I-T to utilise its air intelligence units (AIUs) at airports located in these states and UT to check movement of cash through private jets or commercial flights.

AGENCIES

Crimes against women, failed poll promises, debt crisis dominate TN polls

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHENNAI: Rising crimes against women, failed poll promises and debt crisis would dominate the 2026 Assembly election in Tamil Nadu, though the ruling DMK banks heavily on its social welfare initiatives and investments to seek the people’s mandate for a successive term in office.

Election to the 234-member Tamil Nadu Assembly will be held on April 23. In the outgoing Assembly, DMK has a strength of 132 while that of the main Opposition party, the AIADMK stands at 60.

Corruption allegations against some of the state ministers, illegal sand mining, drug menace, and dynasty rule are also among the numerous poll issues raised by various parties including the AIADMK, BJP, PMK and even the Vijayal TVK.

“The major issue is lack of safety for women and girls due to increasing crimes against them. This is because of the rise in ganja sales in the state,” claims BJP state chief Nainar Nagenthran.

Families across the state live in fear and anxiety as the safety of women in Tamil Nadu “plunges to a new low every day during the DMK regime,” a senior AIADMK leader claimed.

During his “Makkalai Kaapom, Tamilagathai Meepom” (save people, redeem Tamil Nadu) public outreach campaign, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami targeted the DMK on a string of issues including the alleged deterioration of law and order, debt crisis caused by borrowing over Rs 5 lakh crore resulting in a debt burden of Rs 1.5 lakh on every child born, failed election promises, dynasty rule, and scams.

Gyanesh Kumar ducks questions on Oppn move to remove him as CEC

NEW DELHI: Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar on Sunday ducked questions on the Opposition’s notice to move a motion in Parliament for his removal from the post.

At a press conference held to announce Assembly election schedules in four states and a Union Territory, Kumar did not answer questions on the Opposition notice.

While the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) can be removed only by Parliament, Election Commissioners can be removed through a recommendation by the CEC to the President.

In a first, the Opposition has submitted notices in both the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha seeking to move

While CEC can be removed only by Parliament, ECs can be removed through a recommendation by CEC to President

a motion to remove Kumar from the post, alleging a partisan attitude.

The Opposition parties accused the CEC of aiding the ruling BJP on several occasions, especially during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, which they alleged was aimed at helping the saffron party at the Centre.

The process for removing the CEC is similar to that for the

removal of a Supreme Court or a high court judge, meaning an impeachment can be effected only on the ground of “proven misbehaviour or incapacity”.

Article 324(5) of the Constitution says the CEC shall not be removed from office except in like manner and on like grounds as a Supreme Court judge, and the conditions of service of the CEC shall not be varied to his disadvantage after his appointment.

The motion for removal of CEC must be introduced in either House of Parliament and must be passed by a special majority -- a majority of the total membership of the House and a two-thirds majority of the members present and voting.

MPOST

Mayawati attacks BJP, Cong and SP on Kanshi Ram’s 92nd birth anniversary

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Bahujan Samaj Party president Mayawati on Sunday paid tributes to party founder Kanshi Ram on his 92nd birth anniversary and launched a sharp attack on Opposition parties, saying the BJP, Congress and Samajwadi Party cannot safeguard the interests of the Bahujan community.

Addressing a gathering at the BSP’s central camp office on Mall Avenue, Mayawati said expecting welfare of the Bahujan community from these parties was like searching for water in a desert. She urged people to remain cautious of what she called the “deception and pretence” of these political outfits.

‘BSP is the only real party that follows the path shown by Dr BR Ambedkar’

Calling upon supporters to strengthen the BSP movement, Mayawati said people from the Bahujan community should join the party and become committed Ambedkarites. She said the community must use the power of its vote to secure the “master key of power”.

“The BSP is the only real party that follows the path shown by Dr BR Ambedkar. There is a huge gap between the words and actions of the Samajwadi Party and other rival par-

ties,” she said.

Mayawati also warned party workers against leaders who, she alleged, weaken the political strength of the Bahujan vote bank by luring people with positions such as MP or MLA. She said those who betray the party and the movement for personal gain should be kept at a distance.

Targeting the Samajwadi Party, Mayawati said the PDA outreach of the party was misleading. She alleged that parties which have historically exploited Dalits, Other Backward Classes and Muslims remember these communities and their icons only during elections, but ignore them after forming governments.

UNDER AYUSHMAN BHARAT

Study: Need expanded cancer coverage, early diagnosis

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India’s flagship health insurance programme, Ayushman Bharat-Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana, has emerged as a lifeline for cancer patients, offering financial protection and timely access to care that would otherwise be out of reach for most of them, even as a huge gap still exists in annual allocation and requirement, a recently released study said.

The FinCan study, conducted by oncologists and health economists led by Dr Abhishek Shankar, Assistant Professor, Department of Radiation Oncology, DRBRAIRCH (Dr B R Ambedkar Institute Rotary Cancer Hospital) under AIIMS (All India Institute of Medical Sciences) Delhi, provided fresh insights into the programme’s strengths and pointed out opportunities to supercharge its impact.

The AB-PMJAY has undeniably improved access to oncology treatments, the authors said.

According to government

Key Points

- » According to government data, the scheme has helped cover over 68 lakh cancer treatments worth around Rs 13,000 crore since its inception in 2018
- » Targeted therapies accounted for a significant share of that outreach, a crucial advance in modern cancer care

data, the scheme has helped cover over 68 lakh cancer treatments worth around Rs 13,000 crore since its inception in 2018, especially benefiting rural and low-income populations.

Targeted therapies accounted for a significant share of that outreach, a crucial advance in modern cancer care.

A study published in The Lancet found that enrolment under AB-PMJAY raised the

likelihood of initiating cancer treatment within 30 days of diagnosis by about 90 per cent compared to pre-2018 levels.

The FinCan study demonstrated that delivering the full five-year Standard of Care for cancer -- including diagnostics, surgery, targeted drugs, radiotherapy and follow-up -- would require an estimated Rs 33,000 crore annually.

The AB-PMJAY currently allocates only about Rs 7,700 crore per year for cancer under its existing package structure, indicating that a huge gap still exists in spite of reducing the access issues to a larger extent.

Shankar, who led the FinCan Study, said, “Better cancer care is not only about spending more but also about spending smarter, especially where early diagnosis and well-designed coverage can prevent both late-stage suffering and catastrophic costs.”

FinCan models showed that expediting diagnosis and treatment initiation will save about Rs 1,500 crore annually and translate into 1,560 additional survivors per year.

Nation Briefs

CPI ANNOUNCES CANDIDATES IN 25 SEATS FOR KERALA ASSEMBLY POLLS

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The CPI, a major coalition partner in the LDF, on Sunday announced candidates for 25 constituencies in the Kerala Assembly elections to be held on April 9. CPI state secretary Binoy Viswam announced the candidates minutes after the Election Commission declared the poll schedule. The party has fielded four incumbent ministers—G R Anil, J Chinchurani, K Rajan and P Prasad—in the polls. The list also includes legislators who have completed two consecutive terms, including K Rajan, Mohammed Muhsin, E T Taison and V R Sunil Kumar. Poet Alankode Leelakrishnan will contest from Thirissur. In Nattika, former MLA Geetha Gopi has been fielded in place of sitting MLA C C Mukundan.

AAP ANNOUNCES FIRST LIST OF 14 CANDIDATES FOR ASSAM ASSEMBLY POLLS

GUWAHATI: The Aam Aadmi Party on Sunday announced its first list of 14 candidates, including its state vice-president Anurupa Dekaraja, for the Assam Assembly elections to be held on April 9. All the constituencies included on the list are located in the Brahmaputra valley. Dekaraja will contest from the Guwahati Central seat and Renuka Timungpi from Bokajan. Among other candidates named on the list, issued by AAP state prabharaj Rajesh Sharma, are Achyut Das (Naoboicha), Tapan Gogoi (Sivasagar), Zahidul Islam Khan (Chengal), Ranjeet Boro (Nadua), Pallav Saikia (Titabor) and Jinna Amir Hussain (East Goalpara).

Health

- Aam Aadmi Clinics: Medicines and diagnostic tests are provided entirely free of cost
- 2,661 new doctors, paramedics, and frontline staff have been recruited
- CM Di Yogshala: Lakhs of people are benefitted by free yoga classes organised by government

Mukh Mantri Sehat Yojana

**Free treatment worth
₹10 lakh for every family**

Mukh Mantri Teerth Yatra Yojana

- All citizens above 50 years of age are availing facilities to visit sacred places
- Free AC buses and AC hotel accommodation are provided for pilgrims

Education — Punjab Ranked No. 1 in the Country

- Punjab secured Rank 1 in the National Achievement Survey
- Students from 305 government schools cleared JEE Main, and 845 students cleared NEET
- More than 15,000 new teachers recruited, and over 12,000 contractual teachers regularized
- Principals and teachers trained in Finland, Singapore, and IIMs
- Free school buses provided to students in government schools for the first time

Employment

- 65,264 youth received government jobs
- More than 5 lakh jobs created in the private sector

Yudh Nashean Virudh - 50,000+ traffickers arrested

- 50,238 drug traffickers arrested and 32,620 kg narcotics seized

50.12% Reduction in Road Accident Deaths

- India's first Sadak Surakhya Force established
- Road accident death rate reduced by 50.12%
- More than 47,000 people received timely assistance

Corruption-Free Punjab

- Anti-Corruption Action Line: 9501200200 launched
- More than 1,000+ corrupt individuals arrested

Free Electricity for 90% of Punjab Households

- 600 units of free electricity provided
- For the first time farmers are receiving uninterrupted daytime power for agriculture

Sports - 3,100 New Playgrounds

- Olympic medalists awarded ₹1 crore and a government job
- Special assistance up to ₹15 lakhs for athletes' training

Meri Rasoi Scheme

- 40 lakh poor families will receive 2 kg pulses, 2 kg sugar, 1 kg salt, 200 gm turmeric powder, and 1 litre mustard oil free

Agriculture - Highest Compensation in the Country

- Farmers receiving ₹20,000 per acre compensation
- Canal water supply reaching every field
- Highest sugarcane price in the country: ₹416 per quintal
- CRM machines available on subsidy
- Immediate procurement and payments within 24 hours

Mukh Mantri Mavan-Dhian Satkar Yojana

**₹1,000 per month
for every woman
in Punjab**

**₹1,500 per month
for women from
the SC Category**

₹1 Crore Honorarium for Martyrs

- Families of martyr soldiers are being provided ₹1 crore as honorarium

Industrial Investment - ₹1.55 Lakh Crore

- ₹1.55 lakh crore investment attracted in Punjab in last four years
- New Employment opportunities for 5 lakh youth created
- Industrial and Business Development Policy-2026 implemented
- Strategic partnerships with the UK, Japan, and South Korea

Rural Development - 49,000 kms of Roads

- More than 49,000 kms of roads are being renewed
- Modern libraries built in rural areas
- Cleaning of ponds in more than 13,000 villages

Easy Registry/Jamabandi

- 'Easy Registry'- New System of Property Registration
- Registration process completed within 48hrs
- Transparent information of every step through WhatsApp



ENERGY SECURITY ALSO DISCUSSED

West Asia crisis: EAM speaks to Saudi Arabia, UAE foreign ministers

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Against the backdrop of spiralling hostilities between Iran and the US, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar spoke to his counterparts from Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) focusing on various aspects of the evolving situation in West Asia.

Jaishankar held the phone conversations with UAE Foreign Minister Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed Al Nahyan and Saudi Foreign Minister Faisal bin Farhan Saturday night.

“Discussed ongoing developments related to the conflict in West Asia,” the external affairs minister said on social media on Sunday about his talks with the Saudi foreign minister.

On his conversation with Zayed Al Nahyan, Jaishankar said: “Exchanged views on various aspects of the regional situation.”

It is learnt that India’s energy security figured in Jaishankar’s conversations with both foreign ministers.

Global oil and gas prices have surged after Iran virtually blocked the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow shipping lane between the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman, that handles roughly 20 per cent of global oil and LNG (Liquefied Natural Gas).

West Asia has been a major source of India’s energy procurement.

The external affairs minister’s conversation also came at a time India has been trying to forge a consensus position among the BRICS nations on the conflict.

India is the current chair



Jaishankar starts 2-day Brussels visit

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Sunday kick-started a two-day visit to Brussels for talks with his counterparts from member states of 27-nation European Union.

It is the first high-level visit from India to Brussels headquartered EU after the two sides firmed up a landmark Free Trade Agreement (FTA) in January.

The external affairs ministry said Jaishankar is travelling to the capital of Belgium at the invitation of EU High Representative and Vice President Kaja Kallas to interact with foreign ministers of the 27 member states of the bloc at its Foreign Affairs Council Meeting.

“During the visit, the external affairs minister will also hold meetings with the leadership of the European Union, and his counterparts from Belgium and other EU member states,” the ministry said.

“The visit of the external affairs minister coming soon after the historic 16th India-EU summit is expected to further deepen India’s strategic partnership with the European Union,” it said in a brief statement.

India and the EU sealed the free trade agreement -- billed as the “mother of all deals” -- following the summit meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the top EU leadership on January 27.

of the influential bloc, which recently expanded to include Iran, the UAE and some other countries.

Iran’s counter-offensive against the UAE and other Gulf nations following the February 28 US-Israel strikes

on Iranian targets has triggered some disquiet within the grouping.

As the chair of the grouping, India is now navigating the challenge of setting a common position for BRICS on the conflict.

LPG BOOKINGS FALL TO 77 LAKH

No shortage of petrol, diesel or gas: Govt

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: LPG refill bookings have declined to about 77 lakh from 88.8 lakh earlier, indicating some easing of panic buying, even as the government said there is no shortage of petrol, diesel or cooking gas, and supplies remain stable despite the West Asia conflict.

In a daily update on the impact of the West Asia situation, the government said the share of online LPG bookings has risen to about 87 per cent from 84 per cent, attributing the increase to a campaign by oil marketing companies promoting digital booking and discouraging people from queuing up at LPG dealerships for panic purchases.

All domestic “refineries are operating at high capacity and maintaining adequate crude oil inventories,” the update said. “The country remains self-sufficient in the production of petrol and diesel, requiring no imports



of the fuels to meet domestic demand.”

Oil marketing companies have reported no dry-outs at fuel retail outlets or LPG distributorships, and petrol, diesel and LPG supplies are being maintained regularly.

“LPG bookings have shown a decline, with about 77 lakh bookings recorded yesterday (on Saturday) compared to 88.8 lakh bookings on March 13, 2026,” the update said, adding “Online LPG cylinder bookings have increased from 84 per cent to about 87 per cent.”

The government said it continues to prioritise the interests of domestic consumers and ensure uninterrupted LPG

“The share of online LPG bookings has risen to about 87% from 84%”

supply, particularly for households and priority sectors such as hospitals and educational institutions.

Several States and UTs, including Bihar, Delhi, Haryana and Rajasthan, have issued orders for allocation of non-domestic LPG in line with government guidelines.

State governments are undertaking enforcement measures to prevent hoarding and black marketing of petrol, diesel and LPG.

Raids are being carried out in several states, including Andhra Pradesh and Bihar, to check hoarding and black marketing of LPG cylinders.

Officials of PSU Oil Marketing Companies are also con-

ducting surprise inspections at LPG distributorships to ensure smooth supply and prevent irregularities.

“Citizens are advised not to resort to panic buying as adequate stocks of petrol and diesel are available across the country,” the update said.

Priority sectors continue to receive protected natural gas supplies, including 100 per cent supply for piped natural gas (PNG or natural gas piped to household for cooking purpose) and compressed natural gas (CNG), while supplies to industrial and commercial users have been regulated at about 80 per cent.

Commercial LPG cylinders have been placed at the disposal of state governments for priority distribution and are now available in 30 states and Union Territories, while authorities have stepped up raids and inspections to curb hoarding and black-marketing, it said.

Khattar accuses Oppn of misleading public on LPG

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Union Minister for Power, Housing and Urban Affairs Manohar Lal Khattar interacted with members of the public and listened to their grievances during his visit to Karnal, assuring them that their issues would be addressed promptly.

Speaking to reporters, Khattar said Opposition parties should understand that issues related to LPG and oil supply are linked to international developments. Despite global challenges, he said, the government has ensured that citizens do not face any difficulty in accessing essential fuel supplies.

He accused Opposition parties of misleading the public by making baseless claims about a shortage of cooking

“Issues related to LPG & oil supply are linked to international developments”

gas. Khattar said gas agencies across the country, including in the state, have adequate stocks of LPG, and that supplies of oil and LPG are continuing to arrive from abroad in sufficient quantities.

The Union minister said India is a peace-loving nation that believes in living with mutual respect and harmony with all countries. He added that under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the country has been steadily progressing on the path of development.

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Sunday alleged that the country is facing an oil and LPG crisis due to what he termed the failure of the foreign policy of the BJP-led NDA government at the Centre.

Speaking to media persons on the sidelines of the Progressive Punjab Investors Summit, Mann said the prevailing situation reflected serious shortcomings in the country’s foreign policy framework. He remarked that despite Prime Minister Narendra Modi describing US President Donald Trump as a close friend, the geopolitical developments leading to conflict with Iran had adversely affected global oil supplies, contributing to the present crisis.

The Chief Minister said the country should have anticipated the possibility of disruptions



in oil and LPG supplies and made adequate arrangements in advance to avoid inconvenience to the public. However, he clarified that the Punjab government has directed all Deputy Commissioners to ensure that there is no shortage of essential goods in the state and warned of strict action against anyone found hoarding commodities or spreading panic.

Mann said the issue had also been raised with the Union government to ensure

CBSE cancels Class 12 exams in Middle East

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Sunday announced cancellation of the Class 12 board exams in the Middle East region in view of the US-Israel-Iran conflict, officials said.

“All examinations of class 12 scheduled from March 16 to April 10 stands cancelled in case of students from Bahrain, Iran, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the UAE. Exams which were earlier postponed also stand cancelled,” CBSE Examination Controller Sanyam Bhardwaj said.

“The mode of declaration of results in these countries will be announced separately,” he said.

Earlier, the Board had announced cancellation of Class 10 exams in the region.

Punjab CM claims Centre’s foreign policy ‘failure’ behind oil, gas ‘crisis’

Haryana wins 33 medals at Regional Skill Competition

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana once again demonstrated its strong presence in the field of skill development by delivering an impressive performance at the Regional Skill Competition held in Agra, where participants from the state secured a total of 33 medals, including 8 gold, 13 silver and 12 bronze.

Youth from Haryana competed in 49 skills out of the 63 categories in the competition and won medals in 33 of them, reflecting their technical expertise, dedication and hard work across a wide range of trades and emerging skill sectors.

Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Skill Development and Entrepreneurship Jayant Chaudhary lauded the achievement of the participants during the closing ceremony and congratulated all the winners. He encouraged the youth to continue delivering such outstanding performances in future competitions and to further strengthen the country’s skill ecosystem.

Congratulating the winners, Haryana Minister for Youth Empowerment and Entrepreneurship Gaurav Gautam said the youth of the state have brought pride to Haryana through their remarkable achievements.

He added that under the guidance of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, multiple programmes are being implemented across the country to promote skill development and connect young people with modern technologies.

Gautam further said that under the leadership of Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini, the state government is committed to making youth technically capable and employment-ready. Skill universities have been established in the state, and modern, employment-oriented technical courses are being introduced in various institutes to equip youth with industry-relevant skills.

Punjab Investors Summit draws industry leaders’ strong response

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Investors have given an enthusiastic response to the three-day Progressive Punjab Investors Summit held at Plaksha University, with industry leaders praising the investment-friendly initiatives of the state government led by Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann.

Addressing the valedictory session, Chairman of Nahar Group of Companies Kamal Oswal said the summit highlighted that Punjab is once again ready for industry, investment and growth. He noted that several leading industrial houses announced significant investment proposals that are expected to generate employment and accelerate industrial expansion in the state. Oswal



also announced an investment of Rs 1,500 crore for modernisation of existing units, expansion in textiles and renewable energy, and the setting up of a data centre in Mohali.

Industry representatives said the summit helped restore confidence among investors and signalled a revival of Punjab’s industrial environment. Managing Director of Tynor P J Singh announced plans to invest Rs 1,000 crore over the next three

years, citing the supportive policies of the state government.

Vice Chancellor of Plaksha University Rudra Pratap said the institution has already committed around Rs 950 crore to develop a world-class university focused on innovation and advanced education. He also announced plans for an additional Rs 5,000 crore investment to strengthen research, technology and entrepreneurship in Punjab.

CJI: Judicial system must work like hospitals, with same spirit of service

‘Fundamental duties crucial part of Constitution; should be upheld’

MANDI (HP): Chief Justice of India Justice Surya Kant stated on Sunday that judicial complexes should operate with the same spirit of service as hospitals, as people come to courts with hope seeking relief and justice.

While addressing a legal literacy camp after laying the foundation stone for the Mandi Judicial Court Complex, the Chief Justice emphasised that with increasing facilities comes a greater responsibility for the judicial system.

He highlighted that while discussions often focus on fundamental rights, fundamental duties are also a crucial part of the Constitution and should be upheld. He urged the organisation of similar programs at the grassroots level to raise awareness about these fundamental duties.

The Mandi Judicial Court Complex, set to be constructed for Rs 152 crore, will span 9.6 hectares of land and consist of four blocks, providing improved facilities for judges, lawyers, and the public.

KEY POINTS

- » The CJI was addressing a legal literacy camp after laying the foundation stone for the Mandi Judicial Court Complex
- » The Chief Justice emphasised that with increasing facilities comes a greater responsibility for the judicial system
- » He urged the organisation of similar programs at the grassroots level to raise awareness about these fundamental duties.
- » The Mandi Judicial Court Complex, set to be constructed for Rs 152 crore, will span

Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu, who attended the event, stated that it is the government’s commitment to ensure access to justice and rights for every citizen in the state. He mentioned that the government is working toward inclusive development and social justice in line with the Constitution’s spirit.

Sukhu informed that the government has resolved about 5.5 lakh pending cases through Lok Adalats. He said

that through education, healthcare, social security and transparent administration, the government is ensuring that every citizen gets equal opportunities and that the roots of democracy become stronger.

The chief minister reiterated several initiatives taken by his government, including adopting 6,000 orphaned children as “Children of the State,” raising the legal marriage age for girls to 21 years, and granting equal rights to daughters



9.6 hectares of land and consist of four blocks, providing improved facilities for judges, lawyers, and the public

regarding ancestral property up to 150 bighas.

Chief Justice of Himachal Pradesh High Court, Justice Gurmeet Singh Sandhawalia, remarked that the discussions of the day stem from collective efforts to ensure that justice reaches every individual. He noted that justice extends beyond courtroom settings; it also involves awareness of rights, access to legal aid, and the provision of timely assistance.

AGENCIES

CM YOGI ORDERS STRICT SCRUTINY

‘Pandit’ option in UP Police SI exam question sparks row

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

INSIGHT

» Candidates were asked to choose a word that describes a person who changes according to circumstances

» Among the options given in the question paper was the word ‘pandit’, which triggered objections from several organisations and individuals who termed it ‘offensive’

blacklist individuals who repeatedly indulge in such acts. He further directed that a specific clause be included in memorandums of understanding signed with examination centres to ensure that such issues are prevented in future.

The controversy relates to a question asked during the Uttar Pradesh Police sub-inspector recruitment examination on Saturday. Candidates were asked to choose a word that describes a person who changes according to circumstances. Among the options

given in the question paper was the word “pandit”, which triggered objections from several organisations and individuals who termed it offensive.

The organisation Brahmin Samaj of India, in a letter issued on the matter, said the question was incorrectly framed and hurt the sentiments of a particular community. The letter stated that the correct term for someone who changes according to circumstances is “opportunist”, and including “pandit” among the options was inappropriate.

Dinesh Dubey, national general secretary and state in charge of the organisation, said the question not only raises doubts about the fairness of the examination but also appears to be an attempt to tarnish the government’s image and create tension in society. He alleged that it reflected a hateful mindset towards Brahmins and demanded that the question be officially rejected and corrected.

He warned that if immediate action is not taken, organisations representing the Brahmin community across the state will convene a meeting and launch an agitation.

Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak had earlier expressed strong objection and called for an inquiry, stating that strict action would be taken against those responsible.

Saini calls lawyers ‘protectors of humanity’

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday said that advocacy is not merely a means of livelihood but a significant responsibility towards justice, humanity and public service. He emphasised that lawyers are important pillars of the democratic judicial system and play a crucial role in ensuring justice for the weak, deprived and needy sections of society.

The Chief Minister made these remarks while addressing a delegation of lawyers from Chandigarh and Punjab at his residence, Sant Kabir Kutir. He said the legal profession goes beyond the knowledge of laws and acts as a vital medium for ensuring justice, equality and protection of rights in society.

Calling upon young lawyers to contribute actively to society, Saini urged them to use their knowledge, energy and enthusiasm for public welfare rather than limiting the profession to personal success. He said Prime Minister Narendra Modi has also inspired young lawyers to dedicate their efforts towards the betterment of society.

Saini said that whenever he interacts with lawyers, he feels



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini with a delegation of lawyers at his residence in Chandigarh

MPOST

he is among the protectors of humanity. He added that it is a matter of pride that India’s 53rd Chief Justice Surya Kant belongs to Haryana and has reached the highest position in the judiciary.

He noted that the Bar Council associated with the region has produced several prominent figures, including judges of the Supreme Court, Union ministers, Advocates General of Punjab and Haryana, Additional Solicitors General, Members of Parliament and mayors.

Highlighting the impact of technology, the Chief Minister said rapid changes are taking

place in the legal field in the digital era and new technologies are opening fresh opportunities for lawyers. He urged members of the legal fraternity to adopt technological tools to make the justice delivery system faster, more transparent and more effective.

Saini also said the Haryana government is committed to strengthening the judicial ecosystem by providing modern facilities, technological resources and training programmes for lawyers. He added that the state has also successfully implemented the new criminal laws introduced by the Centre.



EDITORIAL
THE KHARG
FLASHPOINT

The escalating confrontation between the United States and Iran has shifted the spotlight onto a cluster of islands in the Persian Gulf that rarely feature in global headlines but quietly underpin the stability of the world's energy system. Among them, Kharg Island now sits at the centre of the latest geopolitical storm. The US strike last week targeted military facilities on the island, sparing its oil infrastructure but sending a signal that the conflict could expand into the economic domain if tensions worsen. Kharg is not merely another Iranian outpost. It is the primary terminal through which nearly 90 per cent of Iran's oil exports pass, making it one of the most strategically sensitive energy hubs in the Middle East. President Donald Trump's warning that the United States could strike the island's oil facilities if Iran interferes with shipping through the Strait of Hormuz — and his subsequent remark that he might attack it again “just for fun” — has deepened anxieties far beyond the Gulf.

Kharg Island's significance lies in the quiet but relentless flow of oil tankers that depart from its terminals. Situated roughly 33 kilometres off Iran's southern coast, the small coral island has long been the backbone of the country's export economy. Its storage tanks, export jetties and pipelines form the logistical network through which Iran's crude reaches global markets. Even during periods of intense sanctions, Tehran has managed to keep oil flowing through Kharg, often using complex shipping routes and discounted pricing to attract buyers. Since the current conflict began, Iran has reportedly exported about 13.7 million barrels of oil through the island. Satellite imagery showing tankers continuing to load cargo after the US strikes demonstrates how critical Kharg remains to Iran's economic survival. Analysts often describe the island as the “main node” of Iran's oil economy; without it, the state's ability to generate revenue would be severely compromised.

Yet the consequences of instability around Kharg extend far beyond Iran's domestic economy. The first major tremors have already been felt in China, the world's largest crude importer and the primary buyer of Iranian oil. Beijing accounts for roughly 90 per cent of Iran's oil exports, with Chinese refiners purchasing an estimated 1.38 million barrels per day last year. Much of this trade is handled by independent refiners known as “teapots”, clustered in China's Shandong province, which purchase Iranian crude at discounted prices. For these refineries, Iranian oil represents both an economic advantage and a strategic vulnerability. Any disruption to shipments from Kharg would immediately reverberate through China's energy supply chain. Unsurprisingly, the recent escalation has already triggered panic in Chinese fuel markets. Retail gasoline and diesel prices were raised sharply — the steepest increase in nearly three years — following a surge in international crude prices. Drivers reportedly rushed to fuel stations in anticipation of further price hikes, creating long queues across several cities.

The ripple effects of the conflict illustrate how deeply interconnected the global energy system has become. Between late February and early March, China witnessed fuel price increases of nearly ten per cent as global crude markets reacted to the uncertainty surrounding Iran. In response, Beijing moved quickly to insulate its domestic economy. Authorities imposed an immediate ban on refined fuel exports in March, a precautionary measure aimed at preventing domestic shortages if imports were disrupted. Such actions reveal the underlying fear that the conflict could escalate into a broader energy crisis. While Kharg's infrastructure remains intact for now, the mere possibility of future strikes has injected volatility into oil markets. Financial institutions and commodity analysts have warned that a sustained disruption of Iranian exports could push global crude prices sharply higher, particularly if shipping through the Strait of Hormuz is affected.

The Strait of Hormuz itself represents the ultimate pressure point in this unfolding crisis. The narrow maritime corridor, linking the Persian Gulf to the Arabian Sea, carries nearly one-fifth of the world's oil supply each day. Any threat to its security instantly transforms a regional confrontation into a global economic emergency. Iran has repeatedly hinted that it could close the strait as leverage against Washington and its allies. Recently, Iran's new Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei suggested that restricting access to the waterway could serve as a powerful bargaining tool. Some reports suggest Tehran may even consider allowing only limited tanker traffic through the strait — and potentially requiring oil transactions to be conducted in Chinese yuan rather than US dollars. Such a move would represent a direct challenge to the dominance of the dollar in global energy trade, introducing a new dimension to an already volatile geopolitical contest.

The islands scattered across the Persian Gulf — Kharg, Abu Musa, the Greater and Lesser Tunbs, and Qeshm — therefore represent far more than geographic features. They are strategic nodes in a global network of energy flows, trade routes and military calculations. Control of these islands provides surveillance over shipping lanes, logistical support for naval operations and, in the case of Kharg, direct influence over oil exports. Their vulnerability also highlights a larger truth about modern conflicts: economic infrastructure has become as significant as military targets. A single strike on a refinery, export terminal or desalination plant can disrupt the livelihoods of millions while sending shockwaves through international markets.

What the unfolding confrontation ultimately underscores is the precarious balance that sustains the world's energy order. A conflict centred on small islands in the Persian Gulf now has the potential to influence fuel prices in Chinese cities, financial markets in Europe and economic policy decisions in Washington. The strategic geography of the Gulf ensures that any escalation will carry consequences far beyond the immediate battlefield. The lesson for policymakers should be obvious. Military brinkmanship around these islands may appear tactically advantageous, but it risks destabilising a global energy system already strained by political rivalries and economic uncertainty. In the geopolitics of oil, even the smallest island can shake the world.

TALKING
SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER
IS A VETERAN
JOURNALIST AND
COMMUNICATIONS
SPECIALIST

When powerful nations preach international law while repeatedly twisting it to suit their very own greed and geopolitical interests, the so-called ‘rules-based order’ begins to resemble power politics wearing a moral costume

STRATEGIC
WATCH



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS
A RETIRED IPS
OFFICER, ADVISER
NATSTRAT, AND A
FORMER NATIONAL
SECURITY ADVISOR
IN MAURITIUS

Pakistan, as it is, is embroiled in a deep military conflict with Afghanistan, and any inept handling arising out of the Iran crisis may further compound its security concerns

Misplaced Morality

Spain's outright refusal to endorse the United States-Israel military assault on Iran exposes a burning issue: Whose rules govern the so-called ‘global order’?

“Nations have no permanent friends or allies. They only have permanent interests.”
— Henry John Temple



As confrontation escalates in the Middle East due to the United States-Israel military action against Iran, Spain has chosen an unusual path in Western politics

To explain each episode. ‘Exceptional’. ‘Necessary’. ‘Justified’. But for the rest of the world, the pattern looks less like a defence of the law and more like its selective application. When Russia invaded Ukraine, the West rightly invoked the sanctity of sovereignty. Yet, when military force is deployed elsewhere without international consent, this principle is suddenly pawned off as negotiable. For the few who are still sane, this hypocritical contradiction has not gone unnoticed.

Global relations expert Stephen Walt says the credibility of any norm depends on consistency. When powerful states apply rules only to their adversaries while exempting themselves, the rules gradually lose legitimacy. “The result is a world where the language of law will survive, but its authority would weaken,” Walt adds. The weakness he propounds is being exposed quite starkly.

Politics of Energy
Behind the lofty language of security and stability lies a prosaic reality: energy. The Middle East remains the beating heart of global oil supply. A fifth of the world's crude flows through the narrow Strait of Hormuz, a maritime chokepoint whose disruption can send shockwaves through the global economy. It is sending those shockwaves now, making geopolitics and energy inseparable.

Iran occupies a strategic position in this equation because it sits astride vital shipping routes, holds large hydrocarbon reserves and exerts keen influence across a region where rival powers compete for dominance. Any confrontation with Tehran echoes far beyond the battlefield. Oil and energy markets react, shipping routes become contested and global energy security enters the conversation.

For long, Western interventions in the region have been shaped by this calculus of greed. The security concerns are real, but they are enmeshed in the protection of economic interests; particularly the uninterrupted flow of energy.

That reality does not automatically invalidate every intervention, but it makes the moral language around such actions appear selective.

The Striking Irony
The Middle East adds another layer of complexity as regional regime here maintains careful or muted responses to confrontations. That is because some depend on Western security guarantees. Others walk on eggs as they protect relationships with both Washington and Tehran. Many are monarchies whose politics are intertwined with strategic alliances. Criticism of Western actions is measured, cautious or absent. That is the sledgehammer of irony striking at the weakening iron of sovereignty.

The result is a region frequently invoked as the justification for intervention, but one that rarely speaks with a unified voice. When criticism does emerge from smaller or more independent actors, it is often dismissed as ideological rather than substantive.

Spain's stance stands out because it challenges this silence. Remember: Spain is not the most powerful nation in Europe. Nor does it command the strategic weight of the US, Britain or Germany. Yet, it has chosen to raise a question that others are reluctant to confront. That begs the itchin-and-the-underpants question: If global law matters, does it apply equally to everyone?

Sovereignty Dilemma
The dilemma confronting the world is illustrated by the covert action carried out by US special forces in Caracas, which brought Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro to New York to face drug-trafficking charges. Washington described it as a “law-enforcement action”. But seizing a sitting foreign leader without that country's consent sets a troubling precedent. Guilty or not, Maduro's abduction raises questions. If powerful nations can enforce their laws across borders, what remains of sovereignty?
Even for countries like India, this

question is not abstract, for its foreign policy has historically been built on the principle of sovereign equality among nations. From independence to the era of the Non-Aligned Movement, New Delhi has argued that stability depends on respect for national sovereignty and the peaceful resolution of disputes. That principle becomes fragile when powerful states claim the authority to intervene militarily without larger international consent.

The issue is not whether Iran's government is right or wrong. Nor is it about defending any regime. It is whether rules governing the global system apply to everyone. Or whether they are subordinate to power. If the latter becomes the norm, then sovereignty for any nation becomes conditional. India understands this risk. It lives in a complex neighbourhood where external interventions and rivalries are more than theoretical concerns. Where the erosion of global norms is not a diplomatic debate, but a strategic challenge. New Delhi is witnessing that challenge right now, and it is growing.

The Larger Lesson
Spain's stand will not change the balance of power in the Middle East, nor will it halt the geopolitical rivalry shaping the region. But it does perform a function. It reminds the world that alliances need not erase independent judgement. That even within powerful blocs, nations can question the moral and legal foundations of military action. In an era of intensifying global competition, this reminder matters.

International order is already under strain. Wars in Ukraine and Gaza, tensions in the Indo-Pacific and rivalries between the powers have created an atmosphere of uncertainty not seen since the Cold War. If the rules governing global behaviour are applied selectively, it will only deepen uncertainty. For the world, the lesson is uncomfortable; that the credibility of global law depends not on speeches but on consistency. For India, it lies in continuing to champion a multipolar order — where power is balanced by law, sovereignty is respected, and diplomacy is not dismissed as a weakness.

Spain's defiance may not end a war, but it exposes an inconvenient truth. It tells every global power and leader that when the guardians of the order begin bending its rules, the world eventually starts questioning economic hierarchy. And the global order itself.

The writer can be reached on narayanrajeev2006@gmail.com. Views expressed are personal

Islamabad's Strategic Tightrope

As Iran tensions escalate, Pakistan must carefully balance domestic sentiment, Gulf alliances and its relationship with Washington to avoid deeper geopolitical complications



Political divisions and regional alliances complicate Pakistan's diplomatic choices after the attack on Iran

targeted by Iran for being allies of the US are also expecting some form of solidarity from Pakistan for being victimised. Pakistan has no clue as to how to address this dilemma, as the military skirmishes are heating up and the region is steadily becoming more volatile, pushing Pakistan further on the back foot. In an apparent damage-control exercise, the government on March 4 told political and parliamentary leaders that Pakistan will avoid getting directly embroiled in the ongoing Iran and US-Israel conflict, while pursuing diplomatic efforts aimed at de-escalation. The assurance came during the closed-door briefing organised for the heads of political parties and parliamentary leaders at the Prime Minister's House.

Chaired by Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, the briefing was attended by representatives of the Pakistan People's Party (PPP), Muttahida Qaumi Movement-Pakistan (MQM-P), Jamiat Ulema-e-Islam-F (JUI-F), Balochistan Awami Party (BAP), and others. Key attendees included PPP Chairman Bilawal Bhutto Zardari, JUI-F Chief Maulana Fazlur Rehman, Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar, National Assembly Speaker Sardar Ayaz Sadiq, Deputy Speaker Ghulam Mustafa Shah, Information Minister Attaullah Tarar,

Law Minister Azam Nazeer Tarar, Planning Minister Ahsan Iqbal, and Minister for Parliamentary Affairs Dr Tariq Fazal Chaudhry. Also present were Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz's (PML-N) Pervaiz Rasheed, Sherry Rehman, and Naveed Qamar. Other party leaders included Khalid Maqbool Siddiqui from the MQM-P, Faisal Subzwari, Farooq Sattar, Abdul Aleem Khan from the Istehkam-e-Pakistan Party (IPP), Khalid Hussain Magso from BAP, and Pakistan Muslim League (Quaid-i-Azam)'s [PML(Q)] Chaudhry Salik Hussain and BAP's Manzoor Ahmed Kakar. However, the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) and part of the grand opposition alliance stayed away from the in-camera briefing, drawing a strong reaction from Prime Minister Sharif, who alleged that the PTI often prioritised politics over national interests.

Significantly, according to an editorial on the subject by Dawn, the most widely read English daily in Pakistan, the country finds itself at a similar juncture vis-à-vis its foreign policy. A brutal war is being waged against its western neighbour, Iran, and Pakistan has feebly condemned the aggression against it. Yet, it is also a fact that Pakistan has a defence pact with Saudi Arabia, which, along with other Gulf Cooperation

Council (GCC) states, has come under Iran's counter-attack. Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar has claimed that the defence pact was mentioned to Iran and that Tehran had tempered its attacks against the kingdom. He also condemned the targeting of GCC states. Pakistan has long-standing cultural, economic and political links with the sheikhdoms, and keeping quiet was not an option. Where the US is concerned, while the American-Israeli aggression against Iran is utterly indefensible, Pakistan has condemned the hostilities in general terms, perhaps not wanting to rub President Donald Trump the wrong way. It is indeed a tough situation for Pakistan to be in, as it has to maintain a delicate balancing act between friends, neighbours and benefactors while condemning aggression against a sovereign state and the assassination of its leadership. It is therefore expected that solid suggestions were made at the in-camera briefing that could help Pakistan ride out this perilous regional storm. This comes even as Pakistan signalled that it could get drawn into the Iran conflict due to the defence pact with Saudi Arabia.

Pakistan's indecisive stance in handling the Iran conflict with the US and Israel could perhaps cost it dearly. Any tilt towards Iran would mean certain angst from the US, and any visible soft corner for the US is bound to anger Iran, which is strategically located on Pakistan's west and may not hesitate to hit back hard when driven against the wall. Pakistan, as it is, is embroiled in a deep military conflict with Afghanistan, and any inept handling arising out of the Iran crisis may further compound its security concerns. According to analysts, at this juncture, Pakistan cannot afford to do that. During its recent military engagements with Afghanistan, the trilateral pact has not come into effect, as Saudi Arabia and Turkey — the other two partners in this defence treaty — remained indifferent to Pakistani concerns. Therefore, Pakistan is deeply entrenched in a quagmire as the Iran-Israel-US conflict assumes serious proportions.

Views expressed are personal

Russia says 28 Ukrainian drones attempting to attack Moscow

MOSCOW: Russian air defence units have destroyed 28 Ukrainian drones heading to attack the capital on Sunday, Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyarin claimed here.

This is a second consecutive day that Russia claimed to have shot down 16 Ukrainian drones heading to attack Moscow.

By noon on Sunday, Russian air defence units had destroyed 28 Ukrainian drones heading to attack the capital for the second day, Sobyarin said in his social media post.

The mayor, however, did not give any details of damage or casualties on the ground.

Due to the waves of drone attacks, Vnukovo and Sheremetyevo international airports in south-west and north-west of the capital had suspended operations, civil aviation agency Rosaviatsia announced.

On Saturday too, three of the four local airports located in the capital -- Vnukovo, Domodedovo and Zhukovsky -- had suspended their operations for several hours, disrupting air traffic. According to the Russian Defence Ministry release on Saturday, 47 drones were destroyed as they approached Moscow.

On Saturday, between 11:00 am and 9:00 pm Moscow time, air defence systems on duty intercepted and destroyed 280 Ukrainian unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) flying over the Bryansk, Kaluga, Belgorod, Tver, Smolensk, and Kursk regions, the Krasnodar Territory, and the Moscow region, the ministry said. AGENCIES

AS IRAN THREATENS TO WIDEN WAR

Gulf Arab states intercept new missiles and drones

CAIRO: Gulf Arab states reported new missile and drone attacks on Sunday after Iran threatened to widen its campaign and called for the evacuation of three major ports in the United Arab Emirates as the war in the Middle East, now in its third week, expands further.

Israel and the United States attacked Iran on Feb. 28, saying they were striking nuclear and military sites and encouraging the Iranian people to rise against their leaders. Iran has responded with attacks against Israel and neighbouring countries in the Persian Gulf.

The war has upended global air travel, disrupted oil exports from the region and sent fuel prices rising.

US President Donald Trump said he hoped countries reliant on oil and gas exports would send warships to secure the Strait of? Hormuz. None responded with firm commitments by Sunday, though some said they were considering action.

Israel said it continued to strike Iran on Sunday as Bahrain, Saudi Arabia and the UAE told residents they were working to intercept incoming projectiles, a day after Iran threatened three Emirati ports, the first time it has done so against a neighbouring country's non-US assets.

Iran had earlier accused the US of launching Friday's strikes on Kharg Island from the UAE, without providing evidence



Israeli air defense system fires to intercept missiles during an Iranian attack over Tel Aviv on Sunday AP/PTI

for the claim. The UAE and other Gulf countries that host US bases have denied allowing their land or airspace to be used for military operations against Iran, including toward the island, home to Iran's primary oil terminal.

Iran's foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, said the US attacked Kharg and Abu Musa islands from locations in the UAE. He called the escalation dangerous and said Iran "will try to be careful not to attack any populated area" there.

US Central Command said it had no response to Iran's claim.

Anwar Gargash, a diplomatic adviser to the UAE president, rejected Iran's claim that the US used Emirati land or airspace for its attacks on Kharg Island.

Iran has fired hundreds of missiles and drones at the UAE, Bahrain, Saudi Arabia, Qatar and Oman during the war. It says it targets US assets, even as Iranian strikes are reported at civilian sites such as airports and oil fields. Though their air defences have intercepted most, the war has caused significant damage and rattled economies in the Gulf countries.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Javed @ Junaid**, S/o: Sheikh Rahman, R/o: Jhuggi No. N-38/370, B-Block Park, Jahangir Puri, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 649/2015 U/s 392/394/397/174(A)/34 IPC, P.S.: Jahangir Puri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Javed @ Junaid** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Javed @ Junaid** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Javed @ Junaid** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 649/2015 U/s 392/394/397/174(A)/34 IPC, P.S.: Jahangir Puri, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **17.04.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Jagmohan Singh

DP/3333/NW/2026
(Court Matter)
Addl. Sessions Judge - 03, (North)
Room No. 312, Rohini Court, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Dhanraj**, S/o Shiv Charan, R/o: H.No. D-1/303, Nand Nagri, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 395/2019 U/s 129/55 G. Act, P.S.: Nand Nagri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Dhanraj** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Dhanraj** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Dhanraj** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 395/2019 U/s 129/55 G. Act, P.S.: Nand Nagri, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.05.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana

Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Shahdara, Room No. 19
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

Whereas, M/s Adore Propmart LLP is in the process of developing of Group Housing Colony over an area admeasuring 9.2453 acres in Sector -- 77, Gurugram, in accordance with the provision of License No. 264 of 2023 Dated 19.12.2023, granted by Director General, Town & Country Planning, Haryana, Chandigarh. And whereas several individuals have made bookings/entered into purchase agreement for allotment of unit in the said colony (here in after referred as allottees). And whereas, the Building Plans earlier approved at the time of grant of licence for the said colony and further revised, is now proposed to be revised. And whereas, the office of Director General, Town & Country Planning, Haryana, Chandigarh has required seeking of objection against the revision of Building Plans as a pre-condition for allowing such revision in the Building Plans. Accordingly, vide this public notice objections are hereby invited from any of the allottees in the said colony on the proposed revision of the building plan of the said colony. A copy of the earlier approved Building Plans bearing Memo No. ZP-1938/PA(DK)/2024/8558 dated 11.03.2024 & the Building Plans now proposed to be revised bearing Memo No. ZP-1938-III/PA(DK)/2026/8815 dated 12.03.2026 is available for perusal on our website www.adorealltech.com. The said Building Plans can also be perused at the office of under signed at First Floor Splendor Tower-II, Sector 58, Gurugram-122001 as well as in the office of Senior Town Planner (Planning), the Senior Town Planner (STP) Gurugram Circle office, Sector 14, Gurugram. Any allottee having any objection on revised Building Plans, may file his objection in the office of Senior Town Planner (Planning), The Senior Town Planner (STP) Gurugram Circle office, Sector 14, Gurugram within 30 days of the publication of this notice, falling which it shall be assumed that there are no objections to the proposed revision in the Building Plans.

Dated: 16/03/2026
Place: Gurugram

Mr. Kaptan Singh
Director

'Israeli strike killed 12 in Gaza'

CAIRO: At least 12 Palestinians, including two boys, a pregnant woman and eight police officers, were killed Sunday by Israeli airstrikes in the war-torn Gaza Strip, hospital authorities said.

A strike Sunday morning hit a house in the urban refugee camp of Nuseirat in central Gaza and killed four people, including a couple in their 30s and their 10-year son, according to the nearby Al-Aqsa Martyrs Hospital. The woman had been pregnant with twins, the hospital said.

The fourth fatality, a 15-year-old neighbour, was taken to the Awda hospital in Nuseirat. "We were sleeping and got up to the strike of a missile. The strike was strong," said Mahmoud al-Muhtaseb, a neighbour. "There was no prior warning." Another strike Sunday afternoon hit a police vehicle on the south-north Salah al-Din route at the entrance of the central town of Zawaida, the Hamas-run Interior Ministry said.

The strike killed eight police



Mourners carry the bodies of two Palestinian policemen killed in an Israeli military strike, during their funeral in Khan Younis AP/PTI

ISRAEL SAYS IT HAS RESPONDED TO VIOLATIONS OF THE CEASEFIRE OR TARGETED WANTED MILITANTS

officers, including Col Iyad Ab Yusef, a senior police official in central Gaza, the ministry said. The Al-Aqsa Martyrs Hospital, which received the

bodies, confirmed the toll. It said 14 others were wounded. There was no immediate comment from the Israeli military on either strike. Hamas over- sees a police force that maintained a high degree of public security after the militants seized power in Gaza in 2007, while also cracking down on dissent.

The police largely melted away during the war as Israeli forces seized large areas of Gaza and targeted Hamas security forces with airstrikes. AGENCIES

PAVES WAY FOR TRUMP-XI SUMMIT

US-China trade talks open in Paris

BEIJING:Representatives from Beijing and Washington began their economic and trade talks in Paris on Sunday, Chinese official news agency Xinhua reported.

The meetings, led by US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng, are expected to pave the way for US President Donald Trump's state visit to Beijing to meet Chinese leader Xi Jinping in about two weeks.

The White House has said that Trump will travel to



China from March 31 to April 2, though Beijing has not officially confirmed it.

Bessent said on Thursday that his team will continue to deliver results that put America's farmers, workers and busi-

nesses first. China's commerce ministry said Friday the two sides are set to discuss "trade and economic issues of mutual concern."

Trump's visit to China will be the first for a US president since he went in his first term in 2017. It will come five months after the two leaders met in the South Korean city of Busan and agreed to a one-year truce in a trade war that temporarily saw tit-for-tat tariffs soar to triple digits before the two sides climbed down. AGENCIES

UN CHIEF REMARKS

'We need to recognise we have problem with Security Council'

UNITED NATIONS: In a sharp critique, UN chief Antonio Guterres said there is a need to recognise "we have a problem with the Security Council", which does not reflect the current world and is not allowed to stop conflicts because of the use of veto by its permanent members.

"I think we need to recognise that we have a problem with the Security Council. The Security Council today no longer represents the world as the world exists. It represents the world after 1945," Guterres said at a press conference in Beirut on Saturday in response to a question.

He pointed out that three permanent members of the 15-nation Council are from Europe, one from Asia, and one is the United States, while there are no permanent members from Africa or Latin America.

Even from Asia, that "obviously is a continent with an enormous weight in global



UN chief Antonio Guterres

population and global wealth", there is just one permanent member - China.

"And so, the Council has a problem of legitimacy and a problem of efficiency because of the vetoes. And what we have witnessed is that time and time again, when we have situations of conflict and when it's necessary to stop the conflict, there is a veto that emerges, and that does not allow the Security Council to act.

That, unfortunately, is something that we are witnessing time and time again, and I am not hoping that in the short term, things will change," he said. AGENCIES

I've 'faith' in Balen: Nepal PM interim Karki

KATHMANDU: Outgoing interim government head Sushila Karki on Sunday said she never expected four-time Nepal prime minister K P Sharma Oli would lose the general elections.

The election result reflects the influence of youth voters and the demand for change as an effect of the Gen-Z movement, Karki said in an interview with state-run news agency, the Rashtriya Samachar Samiti.

The Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP), with former Kathmandu Mayor Balendra 35-year-old Shah 'Balen' as its prime ministerial candidate, bagged 182 seats in the 275-member House of Representatives (HoR).

It includes 57 seats under the proportional representation (PR) after it won in 125 constituencies under direct voting that took place on March 5. AGENCIES

Name Changel

Sangeeta Singh W/o Sh. Khem Singh Rajput R/o PB-199, FF Floor, BPTP Pride, Sector-77, Faridabad, Haryana do Hereby solemnly affirm & declare That I want to Changed My name Sangeeta Rana to Sangeeta Singh for all future Purposes. That Sangeeta Singh & Sangeeta Rana is the Same name & same person.

Name Changel

Manisha Sirohi W/o Sh. Pankaj Sirohi R/o PB-198, GF Floor, BPTP Parkland Pride, Sector-77, Faridabad, Haryana do Hereby solemnly affirm & declare That I want to Changed My name Manisha Sorot to Manisha Sirohi for all future Purposes. That Manisha Sorot & Manisha Sirohi is the Same name & same person.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Hemant**, S/o: Gautam Singh, R/o: H.No. D-3/199, Nand Nagri, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 99/2019 U/s 129/55 G. Act, P.S.: Nand Nagri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Hemant** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Hemant** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Hemant** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 99/2019 U/s 129/55 G. Act, P.S.: Nand Nagri, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.05.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Room No. 19
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/3318/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Vijay**, S/o Prem Shankar R/o Ishwar Colony, Bawana, Kale ka Makan, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.677/15 u/s 33/58 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Vijay** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Vijay** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Vijay** of **FIR No.677/15 u/s 33/58 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.04.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Bharti Beniwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05 (North), Court Room No.114,
DP/3240/ON/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Rajiv @ Bhalle**, S/o: Sanjay, R/o: H.No. F-349, JJ Colony, Raghuvir Nagar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 898/2023 U/s 25/54/59 Act. & 53/166 DP Act, P.S.: Rajouri Garden, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Rajiv @ Bhalle** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Rajiv @ Bhalle** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Rajiv @ Bhalle** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 898/2023 U/s 25/54/59 Act. & 53/166 DP Act, P.S.: Rajouri Garden, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **24.04.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Shashank Nandan Bhatt
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02 (West)
Room No. 356, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/3324/WD/2026
(Court Matter)

Oil cos weigh refinery price freeze, move likely to hit MRPL and CPCL

Global oil prices have risen from \$70/barrel before West Asia conflict to over \$100, but retail fuel prices in India have remained unchanged

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: State-owned oil marketing companies are considering paying refineries a price lower than the imported rates of petrol and diesel to limit mounting losses from a retail fuel price freeze, a move that could hit standalone refiners like MRPL, CPCL and HMEL.

International oil prices have risen from about \$70 per barrel before the West Asia conflict to over \$100, but retail petrol and diesel prices in India have remained unchanged, forcing oil marketing companies (OMCs) to absorb the impact.

With no immediate end to the conflict in sight, OMCs are exploring ways to limit losses on fuel sales, two sources aware of the matter said.

One option under consideration is either freezing or fixing a discount on the refinery transfer price (RTP) - the internal price at which refineries sell fuel to marketing arms - to effectively pay refineries less than the import-parity cost of the fuels like petrol and diesel.

The proposed move would prevent refiners from fully passing on higher crude costs through RTP, forcing them to absorb part of the impact if global oil prices remain ele-



With no immediate end to the conflict in sight, OMCs are exploring ways to limit losses on fuel sales, two sources aware of the matter said

vated. While integrated state-run firms such as Indian Oil Corporation Ltd (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) can offset part of the hit between refining and marketing operations, standalone refiners that rely on market-linked RTP for revenue could face a sharper margin squeeze, they said.

Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Ltd (MRPL), Chennai Petroleum Corpora-

tion Ltd (CPCL) and HPCL-Mittal Energy Ltd (HMEL) - which have negligible retail presence and sell most of the petrol and diesel produced to the three OMCs - would be the most hit by the move.

The changes would also impact refiners like Nayara Energy and Reliance Industries Ltd if the freeze or discount on RTP is also implemented for private refiners, sources said.

The two private refiners sell a bulk of their production of

Highlights

- » One option under consideration is either freezing/fixing a discount on refinery transfer price at which refineries sell fuel to marketing arms
- » It would prevent refiners from fully passing on higher crude costs via RTP, forcing them to absorb part of impact
- » Standalone refiners that rely on market-linked RTP for revenue could face sharper margin squeeze

petrol and diesel to OMCs, who own and operate 90 per cent of the over 1 lakh petrol pumps in the country.

Traditionally, petrol and diesel in India have been priced on an import parity basis, meaning the fuels are valued as if they were imported, even though it is primarily crude oil that is brought into the country and refined locally.

Refinery transfers of these products to oil marketing companies were based on import

parity price (IPP) until June 2006, after which the government adopted trade parity pricing (TPP) - a benchmark that assigns 80 per cent weight to import parity price and 20 per cent to export parity price.

This pricing protected refinery margins, particularly of standalone refiners, who did not have the cushion of marketing margins on petrol and diesel, as the pricing was deregulated by the government in 2010 and 2014, respectively.

Despite being freed, petrol and diesel prices have not exactly moved in line with cost and have been frozen since April 2022, with OMCs absorbing losses when crude oil prices rise and making bumper profits when rates fell.

The move on the RTP freeze or discount move is being examined under-recoveries or losses on petrol and diesel have widened, sources said, adding that unlike cooking gas LPG, the government does not compensate OMCs for losses on auto fuels. OMCs feel the freezing RTP would effectively distribute the financial burden across the refining ecosystem, but analysts say it could disproportionately affect independent refiners with limited downstream marketing exposure.

Adani-Total Gas cuts price for certain industrial customers

About 70% of ATGL's gas volumes are sourced domestically and supplied to CNG & domestic PNG customers

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Adani Total Gas Ltd (ATGL) has cut the price of excess natural gas supplied to certain industrial customers to Rs 82.95 per standard cubic metre (SCM) from Rs 119.90 per SCM, effective 0600 hours on March 16, as upstream gas prices softened amid ongoing supply disruptions.

The city gas joint venture of Adani Group and France's Total Energies said the revision aims to pass on the benefit of lower upstream prices to customers while maintaining system stability and equitable distribution of gas during the current supply constraints.

Following the disruption in India's LNG supplies due to the halt in the movement of ships through the Strait of Hormuz as a fallout of the war in West Asia, ATGL had asked commercial and industrial customers to curtail consumption to 40 per cent of their contracted volumes.

Spot market rates were applied to consumption beyond this threshold. Rates for this segment have not been cut.

"We are pleased to inform you that the Excess Gas Price as informed vide our communication dated March 3, 2026, has been revised downward from Rs 119.90 per SCM to Rs 82.95 per SCM, which will be effective from 0600 hours on March 16, 2026," the company said in a



'The revision aims to pass on the benefit of lower upstream prices to customers while maintaining system stability and equitable distribution of gas during the current supply constraints'

communication to users.

The revision, it said, has been undertaken with the intent of passing on the benefit of reduced upstream gas prices, while continuing to manage system integrity and equitable distribution of gas during the prevailing supply disruption.

It added that other terms announced earlier regarding excess gas provisions remain unchanged, and that clarification has been sought from GAIL (India) Ltd on the 80 per cent supply to industrial customers under the existing order.

Earlier this month, ATGL

had not raised prices of CNG and piped cooking gas supplied to households, even as it had imposed supply curbs on some large industrial consumers amid the escalating West Asia crisis affecting gas supplies.

About 70 per cent of ATGL's gas volumes are sourced domestically and supplied to CNG users and domestic kitchens (called piped natural gas (PNG)-domestic) customers. Prices for these segments of vehicle owners and residential households remain unchanged. ATGL sourced the remaining around 30 per cent of gas volumes through imported LNG. This was supplied to commercial and industrial users.

As the crisis in West Asia disrupted India's gas supplies, the government rejigged allotment by giving priority to CNG and piped cooking gas needs while pooling the price of imported LNG for users.

The resultant lower gas prices are now being passed on to consumers.

Previously, commercial and industrial users who used gas beyond the 40 per cent limit were charged Rs 119 per scm (Standard Cubic Meter) on the incremental volumes.

The company added that it is making every possible effort to ensure uninterrupted gas supplies while managing supply challenges and protecting consumer interests across segments.

Gold, silver may see correction next week: Analysts



NEW DELHI: Gold and silver prices are expected to see more corrective moves for the coming week as investors closely track geopolitical developments in West Asia & key central bank meetings that could affect the trajectory of the global monetary policy, analysts said.

Traders will remain focused on the evolving conflict in West Asia as any signs of escalation or de-escalation could trigger sharp swings across financial markets, they added.

These central banks are widely expected to keep the interest rates unchanged, and market participants will closely analyse their forward guidance for fresh insights on the trajectory of the global monetary policy, Mer said. Bullion prices in the domestic markets remained under pressure during the past week.

On MCX, silver tanked Rs 8,850, or 3.3 per cent, while gold declined Rs 3,168, or 2 per cent.

In the global market, Comex silver slipped nearly \$3, or 3.52 per cent, during last week, while gold fell \$97, or 2 per cent.

Adani Power gets LoA from MSEDCL for supply of 1,600 MW of power

During FY26, APL has won five long-term PSA bids with a combined capacity of 10,400 MW

NEW DELHI: Adani Power Ltd (APL) on Sunday said it has received a letter of award (LoA) from Maharashtra State Electricity Distribution Company Ltd (MSEDCL) for the supply of 1,600 MW of power from one of its upcoming ultra-supercritical thermal power projects.

The supply of power under the proposed 25-year Power Supply Agreement (PSA) is scheduled to commence from the financial year 2030-31, a company statement said.

"This LoA from MSEDCL reflects the competitiveness of Adani Power's cost structure, our ability to deliver dependable baseload power, and our

commitment to supporting India's growing electricity needs through long-term partnerships," S B Khyalia, CEO of Adani Power, said in the statement.

With this development, Adani Power has now tied up long-term PSAs of 13.3 GW, out of its 23.8 GW under-implementation pipeline.

During FY25-26, APL has won five long-term PSA bids with a combined capacity of 10,400 MW.

More than 95 per cent of Adani Power's current operating capacity of 18.15 GW is now tied up under medium-to-long-term PSAs, while over 55 per cent of its upcoming capacity

of 23.8 GW is secured under 25-year PSAs. The MSEDCL bid incorporates a pre-determined coal linkage, ensuring long-term fuel security and supporting reliable and cost-effective power supply.

Adani Power is undertaking India's largest private sector thermal power capex program, expanding its capacity from the current 18.15 GW to 41.87 GW by FY31-32, with investments of approximately Rs 2 lakh crore.

The LoA follows Adani Power's success in a bidding process, where the company emerged as the lowest-tariff bidder, offering power at a combined tariff of Rs 5.30/kWh. The

India's gems & jewellery exports up 3.86% to \$2,680.79 million in February, says GJEPC

MUMBAI: India's gems and jewellery exports grew 3.86 per cent year-on-year to \$2,680.79 million (Rs 24,340.05 crore) in February, following the industry's diversification into other markets, according to the Gem and Jewellery Export Promotion Council (GJEPC). The overall exports stood at \$2,581.08 million (Rs 22,460.13 crore) during the corresponding month of 2025, GJEPC data showed.

From April 2025 to February 2026, total gems and jewellery exports were almost flat at \$25,933.72 million (Rs 2,28,230.06 crores) compared to \$25,915.81 million (Rs 2,18,737.62 crores) in the year-ago period.



"The past year has been challenging for the global gem and jewellery industry, shaped by evolving US tariff policies, geopolitical uncertainties, and changing consumer preferences across key markets. Despite these headwinds, the Indian gem and jewellery sector has demonstrated remarkable resilience," GJEPC Chairman Kirit Bhansali said. Exporters have

Exports of gold jewellery witnessed a 3.23% growth to \$928.85 mn (Rs 8,432.16 cr) in Feb

actively diversified their export markets, strengthening their presence in destinations such as the UAE and Australia, where free trade agreements have played a significant role, while markets like Hong Kong have continued to provide strong support, he added.

Exports of cut and polished diamonds slipped marginally by 0.84 per cent to \$1,351.17 mil-

lion (Rs 12,268.05 crore) in February compared to \$1,362.67 million (Rs 11,860.71 crore) a year ago. Exports of polished lab-grown diamonds grew 1.85 per cent last month to \$113.74 million (Rs 1,033.03 crore) from \$111.68 million (Rs 972.04 crore).

The total exports of gold jewellery witnessed a 3.23 per cent growth to \$928.85 million (Rs 8,432.16 crore) last month compared to \$899.82 million (Rs 7,828.05 crore) a year earlier.

Silver jewellery exports surged by 123.77 per cent in February to \$116.37 million (Rs 1,056.30 crores) against \$52.01 million (Rs 452.39 crores) in the year-ago month.



NEW DELHI: Vedanta Ltd is set to raise Rs 2,575 crore through a non-convertible debenture (NCD) issue after strong demand from institutional investors, including ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund, Kotak Mutual Fund and Aditya Birla Sun Life Mutual Fund, sources familiar with the development said.

The mining major's base issue of Rs 2,000 crore was oversubscribed when it opened last week, prompting the company to exercise a Rs 575 crore greenshoe option, taking the total issue size to Rs 2,575 crore, they said.

The issue closes this week. The three-year unsecured, rated and listed debentures were priced at a coupon of 8.95 per cent, lower than the cost in the company's recent

Vedanta's base issue of ₹2,000 cr was oversubscribed when it opened last week, prompting it to exercise ₹575 cr greenshoe option

to refinance debt and reduce borrowing costs.

Vedanta has seen strong investor interest in recent debt issuances. In October 2025, its USD 500 million bond issue was oversubscribed three times, while an NCD offering in June last year saw nearly 60 per cent oversubscription.

The company has been gradually deleveraging its balance sheet. According to a

recent exchange filing, Vedanta Ltd's net debt-to-EBITDA ratio improved to 1.23x from 1.40x in the December quarter of FY25, with a target to reduce it to below 1x.

At the parent level, Vedanta Resources Ltd has reduced net debt to about USD 4.8 billion as of December 2025 from about USD\$ 8.9 billion in March 2022.

The sustained investor interest comes amid robust operating performance across businesses, supported by higher volumes, cost efficiencies and favourable commodity trends.

The group is also undertaking a corporate demerger that will create five separate listed entities, a move analysts say could help unlock value and simplify its structure.

NHAI increases annual pass fee by ₹75 to ₹3,075 for next financial year

NEW DELHI: The National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) on Sunday said it has increased the rate of its annual pass by Rs 75 to Rs 3,075 for the next 2026-27 financial year. The annual pass facility was launched on August 15, 2025, to provide financial relief to commuters using national highways.

In a statement, NHAI said it is revising the applicable fee for the FASTag Annual Pass from the current Rs 3,000 to Rs 3,075 for the Financial Year 2026-27.

Effective April 1, the revision in the fee has been carried out in accordance with the provisions of the National Highways Fee (Determination of Rates and Collection) Rules, 2008, National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) said.



With over 56 lakh users, the adoption of the FASTag Annual Pass has been growing among private vehicle owners.

The revised rate will be applicable for eligible non-commercial vehicles with a valid FASTag seeking to avail the Annual Pass facility at about 1,150 fee plazas on National Highways and National

Expressways.

The FASTag Annual Pass eliminates the need to frequently recharge FASTag through a one-time fee payment for one-year validity or 200 toll plaza crossings. The pass is applicable for all non-commercial vehicles with a valid FASTag.

The annual pass gets activated within two hours on the existing FASTag linked to the vehicle after payment of the one-time fee through the Rajmarg Yatra App or the National Highways Authority of India website. FASTag is an RFID passive tag used for making toll payments directly from the customer's linked prepaid, savings, or current account.

Coal India aims to ensure power at just price amid West Asia Crisis

NEW DELHI: State-owned Coal India Ltd (CIL) aims to ensure power at a just price to the country amid the escalating West Asia crisis that endangers global shipping lanes and imported coal costs, a senior official of the company said.

CIL contributes to 80 per cent of total domestic coal production and 75 per cent of total coal-based generation. CIL contributes to 55 per cent of total power generation and meets 40 per cent of the primary commercial energy requirements of the country.

"As a low-cost coal producer, CIL aims to ensure power at a just price to the country," the

official said, adding that the country has adequate coal sufficiency to meet the anticipated spike in summer demand, with Coal India maintaining robust stockpiles at pitheads and power plants. CIL's pitheads have an inventory of 122 million tonnes (MT) of coal, while domestic coal-based plants are stocked to the tune of 53 MT, officials said.

In-situ coal exposure at CIL's mines stands at around 60 MT, ready for extraction and supply at short notice. CIL's subsidiaries have also been directed to ramp up the frequency and quantum of coal dispatches under the single-window mode of agnostic auction mechanism, the offi-

cial said.

A few days back, the government had said it was fully prepared to meet any unprecedented surge in coal demand.

The government had said that this year, coal production and supply have outpaced consumption, leading to record-high stocks at thermal power plants and coal mines.

Supplies to the non-regulated sector are up nearly 14 per cent over the previous year. Coal India has a target to produce 875 million tonnes of coal in 2025-26. The company is aiming to meet growing demand despite recent, slight monthly production dips in late 2025.

upGrad planning to acquire Unacademy in all-stock deal

Under the arrangement, Unacademy would continue building online learning products

NEW DELHI: Edtech firm upGrad is planning to acquire rival platform Unacademy through an all-stock deal, according to Unacademy cofounder and Chief Executive Officer Gaurav Munjal.

In a post on X, Munjal said the valuation of the proposed transaction will be disclosed only after the deal closes and regulatory filings are made. He added that he will continue as cofounder and CEO of Unacademy if the deal goes through.

Ronnie Screwvala, cofounder of upGrad, said the potential combination would strengthen the com-



pany's integrated learning model, expanding its focus from K-12 education to life-long learning and professional upskilling. Under the arrangement, Unacademy would continue building online learning products.

CLOSER LOOK

- » Unacademy's global product, Airlearn, is gaining traction in markets such as the US, the UK, Germany & Canada, Unacademy cofounder and CEO Gaurav Munjal said
- » The proposed deal reportedly valued Unacademy at about \$300 million, significantly lower than its \$3.4 billion peak valuation in 2021

Munjal said Unacademy has undertaken several operational changes over the past year, including consolidating company-run offline centres with franchise partners to refocus on core digital learning offerings. The company also carried out

a Rs 50 crore employee stock ownership plan (ESOP) buyback, with around 40 per cent of former employees participating. It currently holds more than \$100 million in cash reserves.

He added that Unacademy's global product, Airlearn,

is gaining traction in markets such as the US, the UK, Germany and Canada.

Earlier discussions between the two companies had stalled over valuation differences. The proposed deal reportedly valued Unacademy at about \$300 million, significantly lower than its \$3.4 billion peak valuation in 2021.

Unacademy has also held talks with Allen Career Institute in the past, but those negotiations collapsed over valuation issues. The company's revenue declined to about Rs 820 crore in 2024-25 from Rs 1,044 crore in 2022-23.

NORTHEAST CLIMBED TO 7TH IN THE STANDINGS WITH 6 POINTS

Andy Rodriguez’s brace gives NEUFC first win of ISL season

GUWAHATI: Two second-half strikes from Spanish midfielder Andy Rodriguez powered NorthEast United FC to a hard-earned 2-1 victory over Jamshedpur FC in an Indian Super League match, marking their first win of the season, here on Sunday.

NorthEast United climbed to seventh in the standings with six points, while Jamshedpur FC suffered their first defeat of the season but remained second on the table with 12 points.

The contest began at a brisk pace with both sides exchanging possession in the opening minutes but struggling to break into the final third.

Jamshedpur keeper Albino Gomes produced a sweeping clearance outside the box in the 13th minute to deny a potential attacking opportunity for the hosts.

The visitors created the first real chance in the 19th minute when Messi Bouli rose to meet Mohammed Sanan’s cross, but his header drifted narrowly wide.

The Highlanders responded soon after with midfielder Macarton Nickson testing



Players of NorthEast United FC (red) and Jamshedpur FC (white), vie for a ball during the Indian Super League (ISL) match, at Indira Gandhi Athletic Stadium in Guwahati on Sunday

Gomes from distance, though the goalkeeper comfortably gathered the effort.

NEUFC looked increasingly dangerous in attack, with Parthib Gogoi troubling the defence before being brought down by centre-back Pratik Chaudhari during a promising run in the 27th minute.

They were forced into an early change in the 39th minute when captain Michel Zabaco was substituted due to a hamstring injury, with Asheer Akhtar coming on in his place.

The Highlanders nearly found the breakthrough just

Chandrika clinches gold as India finish with 5 medals in Boxing

BANGKOK: India concluded its campaign at the World Boxing Futures Cup with a haul of five medals, including one gold, here on Sunday.

Competing across the Youth Olympic weight categories, the Indian U-19 men’s and women’s team delivered a series of assured performances.

Leading the charge was Chandrika Pujari, who delivered a commanding performance in the women’s 51 kg final to defeat Uzbekistan’s Mardonova Nazokat with a unanimous decision to stand atop the podium.

Three Indian boxers finished with silver medals after reaching the finals in their respective categories.

Gunjan (48kg) went down to her opponent from England by a 5-0 decision, while Joyshree Devi (54kg) fought hard but lost 4-1 to a boxer from the United States.

In the men’s 50kg category, L. Ambekar Meetei also settled for silver after losing his final bout to Ukraine.

Earlier in the tournament, Radhamani Longjam (57kg) had secured a bronze medal.

Gill, Mandhana win top BCCI awards

NEW DELHI: Prolific batters Shubman Gill and Smriti Mandhana were named the Best International Cricketers (Men’s and Women’s) at the BCCI Naman Awards 2026 here on Sunday, recognising their outstanding performances in the 2024–2025 season.

Gill won the prestigious Polly Umrigar Award, while Mandhana received the award for the fifth time.

For Gill, it was his second Cricketer of the Year award after first winning it in 2023.

Former stars Roger Binny, Rahul Dravid and Mithali Raj were honoured with the Col. C. K. Nayudu Lifetime Achievement Award, the BCCI’s highest honour, recognising their outstanding service to Indian cricket.

India’s five trophy-winning sides (2025 ICC Champions Trophy, 2025 Women’s ODI World Cup, 2025 U-19 Women’s World Cup, 2026 Men’s U-19 World Cup, and 2026 T20 World Cup) were honoured as well on the occasion.

Gill enjoyed a stellar 2025 and established himself as one of the team’s most dependable batters in the longer formats.

“Firstly, thank you to the BCCI for recognising me with this award. Many greats and legends of Indian cricket have received it before, so it is a huge honour for me to be here. What we as an Indian cricket group were able to achieve last year was truly tremendous — five ICC trophies, something I don’t think has ever happened before,” Gill said.

“I want to thank my teammates because none of this would have been possible without them. I would also like to thank my parents and family members for helping me reach where I am today. Thank you once again,” Gill added.

On the tour of England, skipper Gill led from the front in the five-Test series, finishing as the top run-getter with 754 runs in 10 innings at an average of 75.40, including four centuries and a top score of 269.

Gill also played a pivotal role in India’s Champions Trophy triumph last year, having entered the tournament



Shubman Gill



Smriti Mandhana

Mandhana ended 2025 with 1,703 international runs, including 1,362 in ODIs, the most by any woman in a calendar year

and thank you to the BCCI for supporting women’s cricket the way you have. I hope we continue to reach even greater heights,” Mandhana said.

Vice-captain Mandhana made handsome contributions to India’s maiden Women’s World Cup title triumph, aggregating 434 runs in nine matches to end as the tournament as India’s leading run-scorer and the second-highest overall.

Before the World Cup, the left-hander Mandhana smashed a 50-ball century against Australia in New Delhi to register the fastest ODI hundred by an Indian batter, surpassing Virat Kohli’s 52-ball effort.

Shafali Varma (Best Woman Cricketer Senior Domestic One-Day), Ira Jadhav (Best Woman Cricketer (Domestic), Harsh Dubey (Best All Rounder in the Ranji Trophy), and Ayush Mhatre (Best All Rounder in Domestic Limited Overs Competitions) too won awards for their strong performances across the 2024-25 domestic season.

Indian Wells: Medvedev hands Alcaraz his 1st loss of year

The 11th-seeded Medvedev, from Russia, will face second-seeded Jannik Sinner of Italy

INDIAN WELLS: Daniil Medvedev handed top-seeded Carlos Alcaraz his first loss of the year and advanced to the final at Indian Wells with a 6-3, 7-6 (3) victory.

The 11th-seeded Medvedev, from Russia, will face second-seeded Jannik Sinner of Italy. Sinner beat Alexander Zverev 6-2, 6-4. Alcaraz had won 16 straight matches this year, including titles at the Australian Open and Qatar Open. But Medvedev ended the possibility of an Alcaraz vs. Sinner final. Medvedev had dropped his last four meetings against



Alcaraz, including a loss in the Indian Wells final in 2024. This was Medvedev’s first victory over him since the U.S. Open

semifinals in 2023. Sinner made quick work of Zverev, beating him in 1 hour, 23 minutes. Sinner notched six aces against the fourth-seeded Zverev. Zverev won his first eight points on serve. But Sinner broke Zverev in both the fifth and seventh games to secure the first set. Sinner now leads the head-to-head series against Zverev 7-4.

Neither Medvedev nor Sinner has dropped a set yet in this tournament. Sinner has won his last three matches against Medvedev, including in the U.S. Open quarterfinals in 2024.

In the women’s doubles

final, Taylor Townsend and Katerina Siniakova beat Anna Danilina and Aleksandra Krunic 7-6 (4), 6-4. The victory marked Townsend’s first at Indian Wells and Siniakova’s second. Siniakova also won in 2023 alongside longtime partner Barbora Krejickova.

In the men’s doubles final, Guido Andreozzi and Manuel Guinard topped Arthur Rinderknech and Valentin Vacherot 7-6 (3), 6-3. In mixed doubles, Belinda Bencic and Flavio Cobolli beat top-seeded Gabriela Dabrowski and Lloyd Glasspool 6-3 2-6, 10-7.

Leisure



‘DREAMED OF STARRING in Imtiaz Ali’s films’

Sharvari will star in the film maker’s upcoming directorial ‘Main Wapas Aaunga’

NEW DELHI: Sharvari went down memory lane and recalled attending a masterclass by Imtiaz Ali, where she wished to feature in one of his films, years before she was approached for his upcoming directorial ‘Main Wapas Aaunga’.

The actress shared a post on her ‘Instagram’ handle. It featured a picture of her alongside the filmmaker, followed by a note. “To say that I have been a huge fan of your cinema would be an understatement. Today, as our teasers drop, I can’t help but go back to the day when I attended a masterclass three years ago that you were conducting for Mani sir,” she wrote.



“I remember I put up a story on Instagram that day, manifesting to be a part of your films someday. Little did I know I would see a teaser that ends with ‘A film by Imtiaz Ali’ which stars me,” she added.

Also starring Diljit Dosanjh, Vedang Raina and veteran actor Naseeruddin Shah, the film is billed as an exciting cinematic experience, filled with a contemporary and witty narrative that explores the depth of human connection, the makers said in a statement.

The film, set against the backdrop of the Partition of India, follows a young man (Raina) who falls in love with a woman (Sharvari) in the pre-Partition era, a story that unfolds across two timelines, with Shah essaying the older version of the character and Dosanjh playing his grandson.

The film is set to release on June 12 and is produced by Sameer Nair and Deepak Segal of ‘Applause Entertainment’ and Mohit Choudhary and Shibashish Sarkar of ‘Window Seat Films’.

‘Love Stories will make a comeback’

Filmmaker Zoya Akhtar was at a special screenwriting workshop session

MUMBAI: Filmmaker Zoya Akhtar believes traditional love stories will make a major return to the big screen soon. At a special screenwriting workshop session organised by ‘Whistling Woods International’ in association with the Screenwriters Association of India (SWA), Akhtar was asked what themes aspiring writers should explore.

“I don’t function that way, like, ‘Oh, now they’re (industry) looking for this, so let me write this’. But if you look at it in the past 10 to 15 years, everything gets saturated, everything changes. So, if you look at it cyclically, maybe love stories will come back,” she said.

Love stories like ‘Yash Raj Films’ produced ‘Saiyaara’ starring newcomers Ahaan Panday and Aneet Padda, Dhanush and Kriti Sanon-starrer ‘Tere Ishk Mein’ and ‘Ek Deewane ki Deewaniyat’ featuring Harshvardhan Rane and Sonam Bajwa, turned out to be box office hits last year.

Akhtar revealed that she is currently working on several projects, both as a director and a producer. “We have ‘Dahaad 2’ being shot. Reema Kagti is shooting that. I’m writing two screenplays for myself. We finished one screenplay for Reema and we are currently developing a bunch of scripts with other directors to set up and produce. I have two films planned. I’m writing

them,” she said, without divulging details.

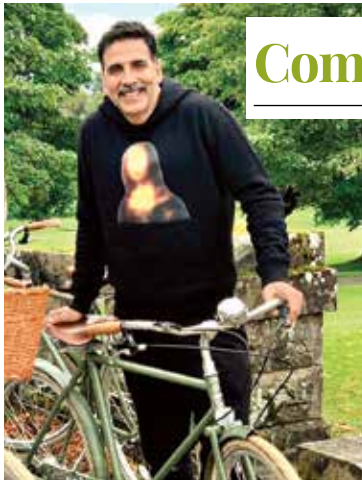
Asked about the sequel to her film ‘Zindagi Na Milegi Dobara’, the filmmaker said, “When it happens, I’ll announce it.”

Shedding light on her writing process, the filmmaker revealed an interesting anecdote about her debut film, ‘Luck by Chance’ (2009), saying the script took shape in an unusual way. The film featured her actor-director brother, Farhan Akhtar and

Akhtar revealed that she is currently working on several projects, both as a director and a producer

Konkona Sen Sharma, and it garnered wide acclaim.

“Earlier, I would write a one-liner for the entire film, like scene one, this happens; scene two, this happens; scene three, this happens, but what I didn’t do then was edit before moving to the screenplay. I just expanded the one-liner straight into a screenplay, which ended up becoming a 200-to-300-page draft. Today it probably would have been a great series,” she said.



Comedy is the toughest: Akshay

NEW DELHI: Bollywood superstar Akshay Kumar credited filmmakers Priyadarshan, Rajkumar Santoshi and late Neeraj Vora for making him understand comedy, the genre he thinks still hasn’t got its due in the film industry.

Kumar attended the second day of the India Today Conclave held in New Delhi on Saturday, where he was asked about the filmmakers he has worked with in the

last 30 years. The actor noted he has collaborated with over 70 directors and starred in 150 films.

“I have worked on around 150 films and I have worked with around 70 directors. But there is tuning with Priyadarshan; it’s fun to work with him. I have learnt a lot of comedy from him. Rajkumar Santoshi is also one of the directors from whom I have learnt a lot,” Kumar said.